HT BENGALURU, NEW DELHI, MUMBAI, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE* VOL. 20 NO. 178

Monday, July 27, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

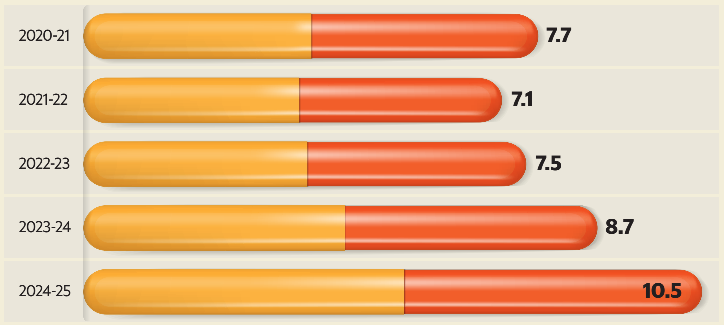
Can drugmakers weather Trump's generics tariff?

BY JESSICA JANI

Trump's proposed phased tariffs on generic drugs aim to reshore manufacturing, but the plan faces scepticism over its viability. If implemented, Indian drugmakers face huge losses. *Mint* unpacks the stakes, the market's importance, and mitigation strategies.

Under threat

India's pharmaceutical exports to the US ($ billion)



Source: Pharmexcil annual handbook

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MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

1 What did Donald Trump say?

On 22 July, US President Donald Trump wrote in a social media post that the US will impose 100% tariffs on generic drugs after two years and increase this to 200% after another year. The aim of this is to "reshore" generic drug production to the US, with penalties for companies that don't build capacity in the stated period, he said. Generics, which are low-cost copycats of original molecules, were originally exempted from Trump's global import tariff rollout last year, which were targeted at branded and patented pharmaceuticals, again, with the goal of increasing reshoring.

2 Why is the US so important?

The US is the largest overseas market for India's pharma industry, accounting for over a third of pharma exports and a significant share of profits for leading drugmakers. In 2025, India's drug exports to the US were worth $9.7 billion, about 37% of its overall drug exports, according to a report by GTRI. Though generics are generally cheap and have thin margins, the US remains a crucial market for India due to its sheer size and higher prices. Generics account for 90% of the drugs consumed in the US, and India supplies nearly half of the generic prescriptions dispensed in the US by volume.

ISTOCKPHOTO

3 How have previous tariff talks panned out?

While Trump threatened innovator pharma firms with tariffs in 2025, it was ultimately used as a bargaining tool to push them to expand manufacturing in the US and reduce medicine prices. It also introduced a 'most favoured nation' pricing policy, urging companies to align US drug prices with those in other developed markets.

4 What do industry experts say?

Most experts and executives believe the tariff threat is a way to bring manufacturing back to the US. However, analysts agree that the two-year timeline is unviable. It takes at least two years to set up a plant, followed by 12-15 months of inspections and product approvals. Also, the US has lost its edge in low-cost manufacturing over the past few decades. Given the low-cost, low-margin nature of generics, setting up facilities capable of producing large volumes would be economically unviable for drugmakers.

5 What are companies' mitigation plans?

Shifting all manufacturing to the US remains unviable for every company. Awaiting more clarity, players like Dr Reddy's have indicated a willingness to consider options such as technology transfers to outsource production to domestic US partners. But while these solutions have worked in other markets requiring localisation, they may not be as viable in the US, given the market's size and cost dynamics. Most leading drugmakers have also been broadening their revenue sources to hedge against US risks.

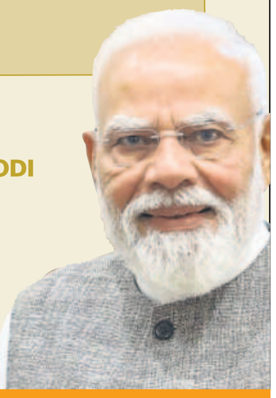
QUICK EDIT

Pyrrhic victory?

Now that Dharmendra Pradhan has resigned as India's education minister and been replaced with Pralhad Joshi, tempers seem to have calmed. At least the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), a youth group that led an agitation for Pradhan's ouster, seems to have backed down. Medical entrance exam paper leaks, the issue that cost Pradhan his post, had turned into a flashpoint of student discontent. In response, fast-track courts are being set up to try the leak-accused and stiff penalties for such corruption might be enacted. Although the CJP is jubilant, its victory may yet turn out to be pyrrhic if Gen-Z still encounters steep odds of career success. And to the extent youth frustrations stem from unmet aspirations, a platform like the CJP can always find new crowd-sourced causes to take up. In some ways, its agitation offered a glimpse of what may happen if the Indian education system doesn't adapt deftly enough to the demands of a fast-changing economy. This is an unenviable challenge as rapid AI advances grant academia no breathing space to catch up. With the future in flux, the 'market logic' of decentralized education—with rival paths free of state control—may serve India best.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

Our examination system should be trustworthy, should be transparent and the system should make maximum use of technology.



NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER

INSIDE

THE WEEK AHEAD

27 JUL ASIA'S BIGGEST IPO
China's chipmaker CXMT to debut in Asia's biggest IPO of 2026.

27-31 JUL IPOS THIS WEEK
Manipal Health, Juniper Green, MV Electrosystems IPOs to open.

28 JUL RBI BOND BUYBACK
RBI to buy back government bonds worth ₹20,000 crore.

29 JUL-2 AUG EARNINGS THIS WEEK
Adani Enterprises, Tata Steel, Sun Pharma, others to report Q1 results.

29 JUL LABOUR PROTESTS
Central trade unions to begin nationwide protests on labour codes.

1 AUG BHOGAPURAM AIRPORT
PM Modi to inaugurate Bhogapuram Airport in Andhra Pradesh.

COLUMNS

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PLAIN FACTS

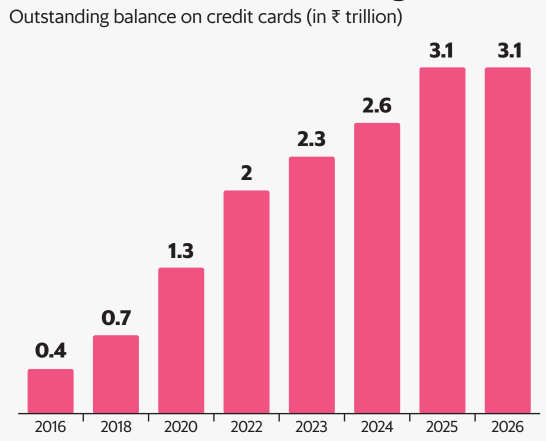
THE LIMITS TO INDIA'S CREDIT CARD BOOM

BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM

In the past decade, the number of Indians with credit cards has grown a good 3.6-fold—from about 14 million in March 2016 to 52 million in March 2026. More than 100 million cards are now in circulation (some people hold multiple cards), carrying outstanding balances of around ₹3.1 trillion. Yet credit card holders account for just 25% of individual borrowers in India, compared with about 80% in the US, suggesting that there is significant room for expansion. A new report by TransUnion Cibil, which tracks borrowers' credit scores, meanwhile, points to emerging strains: rising payment defaults are slowing credit card growth just as consumers increasingly turn to other forms of personal borrowing even as digital lenders increase.

After a post-covid jump, outstanding balance on credit cards has stagnated

Outstanding balance on credit cards (in ₹ trillion)



Data for each year as of 31 March.
Source: TransUnion Cibil

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STRESS POINTS

OUTSTANDING CREDIT card balances have expanded at an average annual rate of 24% over the past decade. But the industry's trajectory has been far from uniform, the Cibil report showed. Between 2016 and 2020, card issuance and spending grew rapidly. The pandemic was a turning point, with an expected rise in defaults as household finances came under pressure.

What is more concerning is that the stress has persisted beyond the pandemic. Growth in both card balances and the number of cardholders has slowed. Between March 2020 and March 2024, the number of cardholders increased by 16 million. Over the following two years, that figure dropped to just 4 million.

The slowdown has coincided with a broader build-up in consumer debt—from home loans to unsecured personal loans. The Reserve Bank of India has repeatedly flagged concerns over rising consumer leverage. Consumer debt as a share of GDP has surged from 39.2% in March 2021 to 45.5% in September 2025.

PAYMENT PENDING

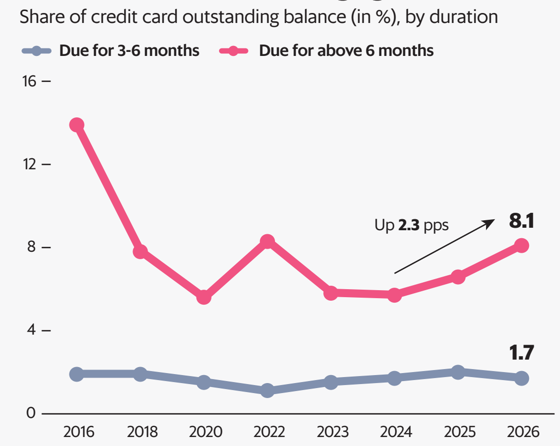
THE STRAIN on household finances is increasingly visible in credit card repayment behaviour. While the share of balances overdue by three to six months has remained broadly stable, the proportion outstanding for more than six months has steadily increased over the past two years, according to the report.

According to the central bank's latest financial stability report, loans taken for consumption, such as personal loans and credit card debt, now account for nearly half of household borrowing. "Consumption-related loans remained the primary driver of household borrowings," it says.

The Cibil report adds another facet to this statistic: the declining share of credit cards in overall household debt, as households now have a wider set of choices in borrowing for immediate personal consumption. According to the report, card balances as a share of the overall consumer credit have declined by 10 percentage points over the last 10 years.

The share of card payments due for above 6 months has started rising again

Share of credit card outstanding balance (in %), by duration



Data for each year as of 31 March. PPS: Percentage points.
Source: TransUnion Cibil

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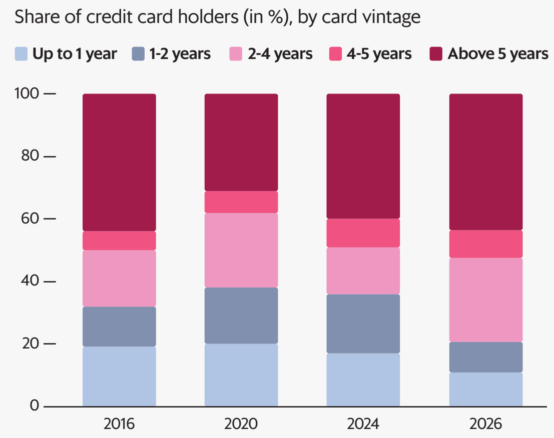
The share of new credit card users is at its lowest levels in the past decade

Share of credit card holders (in %), by card vintage



Data for each year as of 31 March.
Source: TransUnion Cibil

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CARDS AS CHOICE

THE CIBIL report also noted that credit card consumers were more likely to hold multiple credit cards and multiple unsecured products in their wallet. This is seen in the slowing in the growth of credit card users. Those who took a card for the first time in the last 12 months now account for 11% of overall credit card users, down from 20% in March 2020.

"NTCC [new to credit card] consumers are using their first credit card as one of the many credit and payment instruments to finance their lifestyle needs," said the report. Among such consumers, 59% are already servicing two or more other types of personal loans, against 41% a decade ago.

The shift has been acute in the last two years. The share of NTCC users among all card users has fallen from 17% in March 2024 to 11% in March 2026. Yet, the share of users whose cards were issued 2-4 years ago rose 12 percentage points. So, post-pandemic borrowers now account for over a quarter of the credit card base.

SUB-PRIME RISK

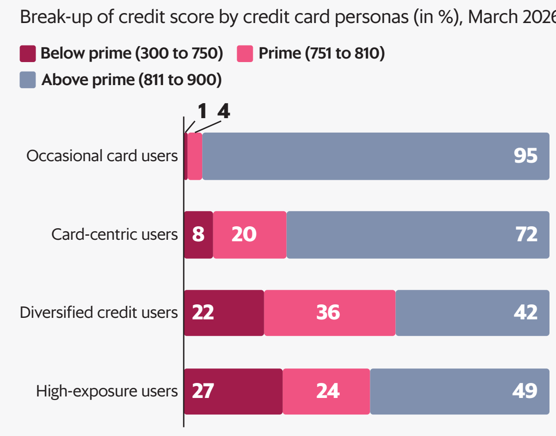
CIBIL CLASSIFIES credit card users into four 'personas' or behavioural segments.

The 'occasional users' (18% of total users) use cards as their main form of unsecured borrowing, but use it rarely—often just to make payments and earn reward points. One step above on the risk scale are 'card-centric users' (33% of users). The card is also their main form of unsecured credit, but they have greater usage, in particular for short-term financing.

'Diversified users' (12% of users) use their cards at a similar rate as 'card-centric users', but also access other types of personal loans, making them riskier. The riskiest category is 'high exposure users' (10% of users), who use cards a lot and also take several other forms of unsecured loans. This category of users has the highest share of so-called 'non-prime' borrowers—those with a credit score below 750. The report excludes a set of overall users from this four-fold classification, as they are either new credit card users or are inactive.

About 27% of 'high exposure' users have a credit score that makes them riskier

Break-up of credit score by credit card personas (in %), March 2026



Source: TransUnion Cibil

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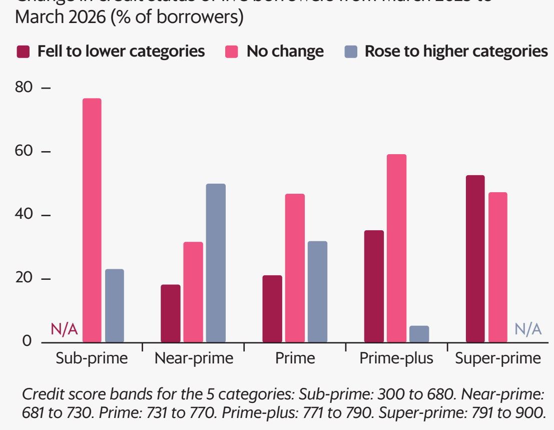
A higher share of 'near-prime' and 'prime' borrowers improved on the risk scale

Change in credit status of live borrowers from March 2025 to March 2026 (% of borrowers)



Credit score bands for the 5 categories: Sub-prime: 300 to 680. Near-prime: 681 to 730. Prime: 731 to 770. Prime-plus: 771 to 790. Super-prime: 791 to 900.

Source: Reserve Bank of India Financial Stability Report, June 2026

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UPGRADES & DOWNGRADES

A LARGER share of prime and above borrowers retained their risk categories in 2025-26 than a year earlier, according to the latest financial stability report of the Reserve Bank of India.

Further, 50% of borrowers in the near-prime category and 32% in the prime category moved into higher categories of credit scores. "While near-prime and prime borrowers saw more upgrades, prime-plus and super-prime borrowers experienced a higher share of downgrades, though they remained mostly within the prime and above categories," the RBI report said.

The sharp growth in consumer debt may have slowed for now, but what's the takeaway for credit cards? Has credit card ownership, penetration, and usage in India already plateaued? Given the robust and increasing competition from other types of loans, the period of rapid growth may be over for the credit card industry.

www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data.

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Inside the Gen Z protest that redefined India ▶P10

Q1 earnings growth may drive markets: Anand Rathi ▶P4

SENSEX 76,059.77 ↔ 0.00 | NIFTY 23,767.45 ↔ 0.00 | DOLLAR ₹96.53 ↔ ₹0.00 | EURO ₹109.97 ↔ ₹0.00 | OIL $92.37 ↓ $1.47 | POUND ₹128.60 ↔ ₹0.00

Price wars pinch IT services as AI rises

Technology firms are slashing prices to win deals from clients

Jas Bardia
jas.bardia@livemint.com
BENGALURU

At a time when India's $300-billion information technology (IT) services industry grapples with slowing growth, it is discovering that the biggest immediate impact of artificial intelligence (AI) is not necessarily higher revenues and improved productivity, but lower prices from stiff competition.

"The slowdown in the market and the revenue compression are creating intense competitive pressure, which is driving prices down and putting pressure on margins," said Peter Bendor-Samuel, founder of Dallas-based IT advisory firm Everest Group. "This trend looks like it will continue for several years."

Clients' demand for AI-driven productivity gains has triggered an intense price war as technology companies of all sizes slash prices to win deals from clients that often choose vendors based on the lowest bid they receive for projects.

The pricing pressure is most acute in coding, application development and maintenance, where AI is automating a growing share of repetitive work. As a result, vendors are increasingly accepting lower billing rates per employee—the industry's traditional pricing metric.

Industry insiders said pricing in application maintenance renewals, for instance, has fallen 4-5% over the past year as clients insist AI-driven productivity gains be reflected in contract values.

During an interview with *Mint* in April, HCLTech's chief executive C. Vijayakumar said the IT industry was facing AI revenue deflation of up to 5% annually, implying that

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AFP

COST CRUNCH

AI ECONOMICS

- **PRICE** war triggered by clients' demand for AI productivity gains
- **THE** pricing pressure is most acute in app development, coding
- **VENDORS** are accepting lower billing rates per employee

iPhone shipments to India fall for first time in four years

Shouvik Das
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NEW DELHI

Apple's iPhone shipments into India fell for the first time in over four years as shortages of its latest iPhone 17 model squeezed supplies to retailers, interrupting one of its fastest-growing markets despite resilient consumer demand.

A 17 July supply chain analysis by independent market research firm Counterpoint found that Apple's iPhone shipments in India fell 3% year-on-year in April-June, marking the first quarterly decline in over four years.

Overall smartphone shipments to retail channels in India fell 10% during the quarter, pushing Apple out of the country's top five smartphone brands for the period. Vivo. Samsung, Oppo, Realme, Xiaomi were the leaders.

The setback comes as Apple is leaning increasingly on India as a growth market. On 30 April, Tim Cook, Apple's outgoing chief executive, had said India's performance had left him "over the moon excited." At the same time, the company has so far shielded the iPhone—its biggest revenue driver—from price increases, although it has warned that may not last.

On 17 June, Cook had told *The Wall Street Journal* that an eventual price hike even for iPhones would be "unavoidable". Apple had hiked Mac and iPad models prices on 25 June but left iPhone unchanged.

For India's retailers, iPhone supply issues, the prospect of higher prices and a weakening smartphone market threaten to dull one of the few bright spots in consumer electronics.

Market research firms International Data Corp. (IDC) and Counterpoint project a 12-15% decline in India's over-

TURN TO PAGE 6

Apple's India iPhone shipments fell 3% y-o-y in April-June. REUTERS

Murugappa, Wipro chase food brand Double Horse

Vaeshnavi Kasthuril & Sneha Shah
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

The battle for South India's spice and packaged foods market is heating up, with Wipro Consumer Care & Lighting and the Murugappa Group vying for Kerala-based packaged foods brand Double Horse.

Manjilas Food Tech Pvt. Ltd, which owns Double Horse, has hired EY to advise on the transaction, a person aware of the matter said on the condition of anonymity, adding the deal is expected to be valued at around ₹500 crore. "The process is underway, and discussions with the short-listed bidders are ongoing. However, no final decision has been taken yet," a second person added.

Founded in 1959, Manjilas Food Tech is among Kerala's oldest packaged foods companies. Its flagship Double Horse brand sells breakfast mixes, rice powders, spices, ready-to-cook foods, pickles and instant foods. Double Horse competes with brands such as Eastern, Nirapara, Brahmins and ID Fresh and Aachi.

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DON'T MISS

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PM announces Nilekani-led panel for education reforms

Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced a six-member high-powered task force headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to recommend technological interventions and structural reforms to overhaul the National Testing Agency's examination system. >P2

Congested ports lift exporters' storage bills

The Federation of Indian Export Organisations has approached the Centre to help mitigate disruptions caused by the West Asia war, including port congestion and surcharges imposed by shipping lines, showed a 22 July letter accessed by *Mint*. >P2

How MRF's promoter family stayed united for 80 years

MRF Ltd's promoter group comprises 102 individuals—arguably the largest family shareholding base in any listed Indian company. Yet, remarkably, the company has seen no public family disputes in the 80 years since its inception. >P5

NOTE TO READERS The Media Marketing Initiative on Page 3 is the equivalent of a paid-for advertisement and no *Mint* journalist was involved in creating it. Readers would do well to treat it as an advertisement.

STRAIGHT FORWARD
SHASHI SHEKHAR

Respond to this column at
feedback@livemint.com

MASS COPYING TO PAPER LEAKS: INDIA'S EXAM MALAISE

The 'cockroaches' are returning from Jantar Mantar after education minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned on Saturday. Their successful movement brought back memories of vintage Indian politics where students weren't mere voters, but the first line of resistance against injustice and oppression. These youngsters have shown that they aren't a crowd but a wave that has the capacity to bring about huge change.

Yet, this movement is leaving behind many questions. What's the permanent solution to the pressing issue riling the youth? There are no easy answers.

Let me take you five decades earlier. It was 1975 and I appeared for class X exams in Mainpuri. I saw about a dozen boys trying to break bricks into small pieces right outside the class. They stuffed the stones into their pockets. As soon as the papers were distributed, they tied them to the pieces of brick and threw them outside the college premises. After some time, the same brick pieces began landing back inside the campus. The papers attached to them contained the answers to the question paper, presenting an outstanding example of Uttar Pradesh's mass copying 'movement'.

Students, teachers, administration, parents and anti-social elements were all involved in it. In the absence of modern communication tools those who wanted to cheat and their facilitators found the going tough. Some years later, the advent of photocopying machines made the operation far easier. The paper would leak at one centre and quickly spread across the city.

Organized copying rackets trace their roots here.

Fax machines now gave power to any corrupt teacher, education board officer or anyone in the system to 'leak' it across the state within minutes. To run the operations like a well-oiled machine, operators of colleges that mushroomed away from district headquarters began minting money, further strengthening the roots of the copying mafia.

Internet, social media and messaging apps gave wings to this mafia. Exams became centralized too. Many education boards, universities and public service commissions started organizing exams. It was expected that the new communication technology would help increase secrecy and integrity of the exam process. But corrupt operators turned it into a money-spinning game.

Youngsters have shown that they aren't a crowd but a wave that can bring about huge change

The luxury of cheating can only be afforded by the rich, not by the poor, hence the resentment. This is the reason the demonstration in Delhi started spreading throughout the country. Use of force on demonstrators and leader of opposition Rahul Gandhi along with Priyanka Gandhi and Akhilesh Yadav's sit-in outside the prime minister's residence made international media headlines.

Was our government oblivious to it? No. Allegations of mishandling in marking did appear after the NEET retest but the papers didn't leak. Prime Minister Narendra Modi declared that the arrested culprits would be quickly punished in fast-track courts. He promised to toughen laws and the next day the Cabinet cleared it. It will be tabled in Parliament today. Meanwhile, Sonam Wangchuk ended his fast. He dropped his demand for the education minister's resignation. Still, the demonstrators and the opposition remained adamant. On Saturday, Pradhan resigned, but the larger question remains: since when has a minister's resignation ever addressed the root of the problem?

To answer this question let me take you back in time once more. It was November 1956. A terrible rail accident happened in Tamil Nadu's Ariyalur. A visibly upset railway minister Lal Bahadur Shastri resigned on moral grounds. He became a paragon of morality but did it help in stopping railway accidents?

Data tells us that between 1960 and **2019** railways recorded 38,500 accidents, killing thousands of people. Similarly, after a minor air mishap at Delhi airport in 1993, then civil aviation minister Madhavrao Scindia resigned as did home minister Shivraj Patil after the 2008 Mumbai terror attack. Since then, have the air crashes or terror attacks stopped? It's clear setting the system straight is more important than a minister's resignation. Removal of ministers and punishment of accused don't deter the criminals from perpetrating crime. After the 2012 Nirbhaya gangrape and murder incident, stricter laws were passed. But rapes didn't stop.

Unless the government and the society work together, social ills can't be eradicated. Paper leak and cheating are also a social ill. Those who leak question papers and the cheating mafia may be criminals in the eyes of the government but who uses their service? What kind of parents encourage their children to cheat and spend money for it? We will have to look inward for answers.

Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, Hindustan. *Views are personal.*

New rural work scheme has women in two of three jobs

Women are taking up leadership roles, with around 61% worksites making them supervisors

Vijay C Roy & Dhirendra Kumar
NEW DELHI

India's revamped rural jobs programme is emerging as an early driver of women's economic participation, with them contributing nearly two-thirds of the work generated in the scheme's first three weeks, according to government officials and data reviewed by *Mint*.

The development can be attributed to the scheme's expanded and more inclusive framework, which has opened up new avenues beyond manual labour, the officials said.

Women accounted for over 63% of the 46.2 million person-days generated under the Viksit Bharat–Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-GRAM G) during 1-20 July, the first 20 days of rollout. A 'person-day' here means one person employed for one day. So, if 100 workers are employed for 10 days each, it generates 1,000 person-days of employment under the scheme.

The data for women's participation in July 2025 under the erstwhile Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) is not available. In the entire financial year 2026, women accounted for 57.3% of the total person-days, the data showed.

For context, in July 2025, MGNREGA had generated 20.17 million person-days of employment, and this year, it generated 17.43 million in April, 27.40 in May and 29.29 million in June before the revamped scheme was adopted.

By integrating childcare with employment, the scheme seeks to make rural public works more inclusive and conducive to sustained participation of women. MINT

₹327.4 National average daily wage under VB–G RAM G

According to the data, the states where women's participation has exceeded the national average include Kerala (participation was 89%), Tamil Nadu (87%), Rajasthan (74%), Himachal Pradesh (70%), Assam (67%), Manipur (65%) and Andhra Pradesh (64%).

Under the revamped scheme, women are taking up leadership roles, with around 61% worksites appointing them as supervisors (or mates) for strengthening workplace monitoring and community engagement.

The expanded work framework includes roles such as worksite supervisors, participation in social audits and employment in managing nurseries, compost and vermicompost units, self-help group infrastructure, storage facilities and rural haats, among others.

125 Number of days of employment under VB-GRAM G

Rohit Kansal, secretary in the rural development ministry said, "With women contributing over 63% of the total person days generated so far and assuming leadership roles as 'mates' at a large number of worksites, VB GRAM G is emerging as a strong platform for women's economic empowerment and grassroots leadership."

"This momentum is being reinforced through policy measures that address the practical barriers to women's participation. The VB GRAM G Act incorporates a dedicated childcare provision, under which a woman worker is appointed and paid at the prescribed wage rate at worksites where five or more children below the age of five are present," he added.

By integrating childcare and support with employment, the framework seeks to make rural public works more inclusive, gender-responsive and conducive to sustained participation of women.

Under the VB-GRAM G scheme, the statutory employment guarantee has been expanded to 125 days from 100 days under MGNREGA. Under MGNREGA, the Centre bore 100% of the wage costs, or bulk of the expenditure, and states contributed 25% of the material costs. But under the new norms, the Centre will fund only 60% of the total cost in most states, and 90% in north-eastern and Himalayan states.

The national average notified daily wage has been raised from ₹298.8 under the erstwhile MGNREGA to ₹327.4 under VB–G RAM G, representing an average rise of ₹28.6 a day. The minimum wage under the scheme is ₹300 per day.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Monsoon set to revive on 28 Jul in North-west

Vijay C Roy
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NEW DELHI

Monsoon activity is set to revive across north-west India from 28 July after remaining subdued over Punjab, Haryana and Chandigarh until the night of 27 July, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said in an update Sunday, offering relief for paddy-growing regions. Meanwhile, a depression over the Bay of Bengal has raised risks of flooding in parts of eastern India.

The IMD has forecast widespread rainfall over Haryana, Chandigarh and Delhi, and fairly widespread rainfall over Punjab between 28 July and 31 July. Himachal Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir, Ladakh and Uttarakhand are also expected to receive widespread rainfall through 1 August, while rain activity is likely to expand to western Uttar Pradesh and east Rajasthan later this week.

The fresh spell is expected to support paddy cultivation in parts of northwest India, where monsoon activity has remained weak. Improved rainfall is likely to replenish soil moisture, raise reservoir levels and accelerate paddy transplantation in Punjab, Haryana, western Uttar Pradesh and adjoining regions, farmers and agricultural experts said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Modi touts India's defence production

PTI
feedback@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday asserted that India is continuously scaling new heights in defence production, military exports and also in the field of political cooperation with friendly nations.

Addressing his monthly radio broadcast *Mann Ki Baat*, he also paid tributes to those who sacrificed their lives during the Kargil war in 1999.

The prime minister, however, did not refer to the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led protests on the NEET paper leak issue which concluded on Saturday after the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Education Minister and acceptance of the protesters' other demands by the government.

Recording of the *Mann Ki Baat* is normally done two to three days ahead of the scheduled broadcast.

Referring to the 'Kargil Vijay Diwas', the prime minister said there are certain days in people's lives that do not require a calendar to be remembered.

"Today, the 26th of July, is one such date. Today is 'Kargil Vijay Diwas'. This day fills us with pride. This day reminds us of the extraordinary courage of our brave soldiers.

"Towering peaks of Kargil, harsh weather, the challenge posed by the enemy - our soldiers faced every such circumstance, yet their spirit was greater than every challenge," he said.

Modi said alongside the courage of the soldiers, India is strengthening its technological capabilities

Modi said India of today not only remembers her heroes but also conveys their saga to the new generation and, with this very sentiment, a special 'Shaurya Vijay Yatra' has been organised this year.

The prime minister said alongside the courage of the soldiers, India is also continuously strengthening its technological capabilities.

Nilekani to lead panel on education reforms

Sanjay Maurya & Smriti Kak Ramachandran
letters@hindustantimes.com
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced a six-member high-powered task force headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to recommend technological interventions and structural reforms to overhaul the National Testing Agency's (NTA) examination system.

The announcement came a day after the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan following a 36-day student agitation over irregularities in the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate) (NEET-UG), the entrance exam for undergraduate medical courses, and a day before the government is set to introduce a bill in Parliament providing for imprisonment of up to 10 years and fines of up to ₹10 crore for those convicted of exam paper leaks.

In a video message posted on Instagram, Modi said the government had already established fast-track courts to try examination malpractice cases and was moving to strengthen the legal framework, but said broader reforms were needed to restore confidence in the examination system.

"Our examination system needs to be reliable and transparent, and it must make maximum use of technology. Keeping all these factors in mind, we have decided to constitute a high-powered task force under the leadership of the world-renowned technology expert Nandan Nilekani. This task force will focus on examination reforms, and based on its report, steps will be taken to ensure the credibility of upcoming examinations at the earliest," he said.

Hindustan Times

Apart from Nilekani, the panel will comprise former Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) chairman S Somanath, former Intelligence Bureau director Tapan Deka, Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Madras director V Kamakoti, former education secretary Anita Karwal and logistics expert Amrit Lal Meena.

According to people aware of the matter, the multidisciplinary group has been tasked with recommending technological interventions and structural reforms for the National Testing Agency, with a particular focus on strengthening the examination system through technology.

Nandan Nilekani chosen to head NTA reform panel. MINT

The Congress questioned the need for a fresh panel, arguing that the Centre was yet to fully implement the recommendations of the K Radhakrishnan Committee, constituted in June 2024 after the NEET-UG controversy that year.

The seven-member committee headed by former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan submitted its report in October 2024, recommending structural strengthening of the NTA, closer coordination with states, tighter oversight of outsourced vendors and stronger safeguards for both pen-and-paper and computer-based examinations,s including encrypted digital transmission of question papers, multi-layer access controls, real-time audit trails and enhanced CCTV surveillance.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh alleged that the government had not implemented all 101 recommendations of the panel and had left the NTA without a full-time director general for much of the period between the 2024 and 2026 exam controversies.

In a post on X, he described the new task force as "a high-powered attempt to fix the Pradhan Mantri's irretrievably compromised image."

After Subodh Kumar Singh was removed as NTA director general in June 2024 following the NEET-UG controversy, retired IAS officer Pradeep Singh Kharola was given additional charge of the post until Abhishek Singh took over as the agency's full-time director general on April 1, 2026.

Govt lowers anaemia threshold for young children, pregnant women

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NEW DELHI

The Union health ministry has lowered the haemoglobin threshold used to diagnose anaemia in two of India's highest-risk groups—young children and pregnant women in their second trimester—as it revamps the country's flagship anaemia-control programme to focus more on targeted screening and treatment than universal iron supplementation.

The revised *Anemia Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan* framework aligns national clinical guidelines with the World Health Organization's 2024 recommendations, according to a government official and documents reviewed by *Mint*.

The revised framework has been shared with states and Union territories for implementation. Under the new guidelines, the haemoglobin cut-off for children aged 6-23 months and pregnant women in their second trimester has been lowered by 0.5g per decilitre to 10.5g/dL. Thresholds for all other population groups remain unchanged.

The changes come against the backdrop of persistently high anaemia prevalence in India. The 2019-21 National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5) found that anaemia affected 67.1% of children aged 6-59 months, 57% of women aged 15-49 years, 52.2% of pregnant women and 59.1% of adolescent girls. Anaemia is a condition in which the red blood cell count or haemoglobin concentration falls below established levels, reducing the blood's ability to carry oxygen.

The haemoglobin cut-off for pregnant women in their second trimester has been lowered by 0.5g per decilitre to 10.5g/dL.

"As per the WHO Haemoglobin cut offs (2024), there is a modification in the haemoglobin cut-offs for defining anaemia for two population groups, children 6-23 months of age and pregnant women in the second trimester, both being reduced by 0.5 g/dl from 11g/dl to 10.5g/dl, rest of the values remain the same as those of 2011," according to the operational guidelines of *Anemia Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan* posted on the health ministry website.

Queries emailed to the health ministry remained unanswered until press time.

The new norms also mark a shift in how the government plans to tackle anaemia.

"The operational shift forms part of a strategy transitioning away from blanket prophylactic iron distribution toward targeted, screening-led therapeutic management. The health ministry expanded the program's lifecycle target groups by adding low birth weight infants aged 0 to 6 months. Under the protocol, infants born with low birth weight will undergo specialist-guided evaluation to build iron reserves early and interrupt intergenerational deficiency cycles. Point-of-care testing across community and field settings will rely on portable digital invasive hemoglobinometers to categorize cases into mild, moderate, or severe stages," an official familiar with the matter said.

The redesigned programme replaces the earlier three-tier approach with a four-stage Test, Treat, Talk and Track model, anchored in a 7x7x7 strategy spanning seven beneficiary groups, seven interventions and seven institutional mechanisms.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

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First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

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Free AI pilot pain eases for startups, but scale eludes

Startups with strong offerings are converting over half of their pilots into paid contracts

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NEW DELHI

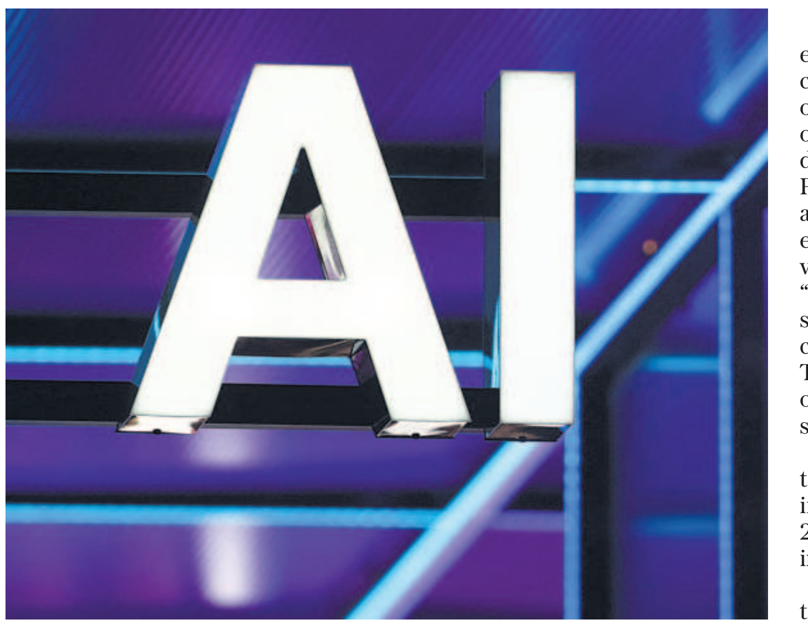
Amid the rapidly expanding universe of business-to-business (B2B) artificial intelligence (AI) startups, enterprises are now increasingly willing to pay for projects rather than seek free pilots—a sign of the market's growing confidence and maturity. However, most startups are yet to secure the large, multi-year contracts needed to scale, setting the stage for consolidation in the sector.

As per Tracxn, the total number of AI native startups in India rose from 182 in 2022 to 465 in 2025 and 246 now.

The commercial shift coincides with faster enterprise adoption of AI. About 40% of Indian respondents saw significant or full AI usage, compared with a global average of about 28%, according to Deloitte's March report, 'State of AI in the Enterprise 2026: India Insights'.

Experts say while the era of free pilots is "largely over", most contracts remain limited to departmental deployments, scoped implementations or paid pilots, rather than multi-year, enterprise-wide contracts with predictable renewals. "More than half of new engagements between enterprises and AI startups still begin as proof-of-concepts. However, the era of free pilots is largely over. Enterprises are increasingly willing to pay for pilots, if there are clearly defined success metrics and a credible path to production deployment," said Sanjay Dawar, partner and leader, One Consulting, PwC India.

However, for startups with "strong, differentiated offerings", the pilot-to-production conversion rates have improved, with many now converting well over half of their pilots into paying annual contracts, Dawar said.



Experts say while the era of free pilots is "largely over," most contracts remain limited to departmental deployments. REUTERS

Experts say this isn't true for all. Many continue to offer free pilots for credibility and enterprise users.

"Many Indian companies are still hesitant to adopt AI, viewing it as a passing hype. Multinationals, on the other hand, understand the technology and see its value, but their local executives often lack authority to onboard startups," Jayanth N. Kolla, founder & partner at Convergence Catalyst, an applied AI venture studio. "Decisions typically need multiple approvals, including from global teams, causing many deals to fall through. So, AI startups are increasingly offering free pilots to win enterprise logos, build credibility and prove value of their products."

"The bigger challenge is not getting enterprises interested in AI; it is moving from an interesting pilot to a production deployment before the startup exhausts its time, resources, and compute costs," said Ankit Bose, head of AI at Nasscom. "Long procurement cycles, extensive customization and unclear ownership continue to slow this transition."

PILOT PIVOT

MANY AI startups continue to offer free pilots to build credibility and win customers

THE major challenge for startups is to convert pilots into production deployment

MANY Indian companies are still hesitant to adopt AI, viewing it as a passing hype

A key reason for AI startups shutting down is the pace at which technology is evolving

As competition intensifies, experts expect the B2B AI sector to see more consolidation and startup shutdowns over the next few years. "The demand opportunity is substantial, but consolidation is also inevitable," said Dawar of PwC. He said funding concentration among a handful of market leaders, and enterprise preference for a few trusted vendors make it harder for startups. "Many of today's application layer AI startups are unlikely to exist in their current form three years from now. This should be viewed as a natural stage of market maturation, rather than a sign of ecosystem weakness," he added.

For context, the number of startups that shut down in this space have increased from three in 2020 to 18 in 2025, with most of them shutting down in the seed stage itself, per Tracxn data.

Another reason for AI startups shutting is the pace at which tech is evolving: a startup can become obsolete not just due to a competitor, but because a new foundation model, open-source release, hyperscaler feature, or platform company bundles the same capability into an existing product.

"Some are pivoting. Some are shutting and restarting. Some find that their old tech stack or old go-to-market model no longer fits the market. That should not automatically be read as a weakness.... It is also creative destruction," Kompella said.

Analysts say India's AI opportunity is significant, as banks, insurers, IT services firms, GCCs, retailers, healthcare firms and government agencies expand AI adoption.

But success needs more than just a chatbot or automation tool. Startups with proprietary data, expertise, enterprise-ready products and repeatable deployment models may emerge as long-term winners, experts said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Bihar picks PNB to steer its landmark power utility IPO

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As of 31 March 2025, BSPTCL had total assets of ₹21,112 crore and liabilities of ₹6,471 crore. REUTERS

The Bihar government has begun work on what could become India's first public listing of a state-owned power transmission utility, appointing Punjab National Bank's (PNB) investment advisory arm to steer the pre-initial public offering process for Bihar State Power Transmission Co. Ltd (BSPTCL), according to three people familiar with the matter.

The appointment marks the first step in preparing BSPTCL for a share sale expected to raise at least ₹1,000 crore at a valuation of more than ₹10,000 crore, one of the people said.

The company issued a request for proposal in April, inviting bids from merchant bankers for the transaction. Punjab National Bank's investment advisory arm was subsequently appointed to lead the pre-IPO work after emerging as the lowest bidder, this person said.

"The initial phase with PNB Investment Services (Ltd) involves assessing financial readiness and capital structure optimisation before finalizing book-running lead managers," this person added.

The selection of merchant banks to manage the IPO is expected to be completed within the next few weeks

The selection of merchant banks to manage the IPO is expected to be completed within the next few weeks, after which work on the offer documents is likely to begin over the following three to six months, the person cited above said, requesting anonymity because the information is private.

The offering is planned as a mix of a fresh issue of equity shares and an offer for sale by the Bihar government, according to a second person familiar with the matter.

"Proceeds from the fresh issue are intended to fund state transmission infrastructure projects, and the OFS component will allow the state government to monetize a portion of its holding," the second person said.

The fresh issue proceeds will help fund BSPTCL's ₹16,194-crore expansion plan aimed at enhancing network capacity, strengthening intra-state transmission corridors and handling rising power demand.

As of 31 March 2025, BSPTCL had total assets of ₹21,112 crore and liabilities of ₹6,471 crore. Bihar State Power (Holding) Co. currently owns 100% of the transmission utility.

A third person confirmed the developments but cautioned that the valuation and size of the share sale could change based on the advice of the merchant bankers.

Executives at Bihar's energy department and Punjab National Bank's investment advisory arm declined to comment.

Emails seeking comment did not receive a response until press time.

The listing plans are gathering pace as Bihar prepares for a sharp rise in electricity demand over the rest of the decade.

In a video interview with news agency *PTI* in March 2026, then Bihar energy secretary Manoj Kumar Singh described the IPO as a natural progression for the utility.

"Our transmission company has been consistently profitable for over a decade.

We want the public to also share in this growth journey," he had said.

BSPTCL's net profit rose nearly sixfold to ₹286 crore in FY25 from ₹49.5 crore a year earlier, while revenue increased 47% to ₹1,785 crore. The company's FY26 financials are not yet available.

Singh had also told *PTI* that Bihar recorded peak power demand of about 8,800MW last year, which was expected to rise to around 9,500MW this year.

By 2030, peak demand is projected to exceed 13,000MW, driven by growth in commercial and industrial establishments.

	S&P BSE Sensex	Nifty 50	Nifty 500	Nifty Next 50	Nifty 100	S&P BSE Mid-cap	S&P BSE Small Cap
CLOSE	76,059.77	23,767.45	22,913.30	71,766.00	24,840.75	16,683.27	6,924.45
1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	-2.68	-2.33	-1.81	-0.09	-1.92	-1.41	-2.41
1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-1.21	-1.06	-0.92	-0.41	-0.94	-0.09	-2.08
3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-0.79	-0.55	1.52	2.69	0.05	4.03	6.00
6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-6.72	-5.11	0.91	4.07	-2.85	7.94	13.78
1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-7.45	-5.17	-1.66	5.22	-3.35	2.95	-2.49


So far this year, 36 companies have launched their IPOs, including nine that hit the primary market this month.

IPO buzz: over a dozen firms set for debut in Aug

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Coming month is likely to witness an IPO rush with more than a dozen companies, including Zepto, Truhome Finance and logistics platform Shiprocket gearing up to launch their initial share-sale.

The upcoming issues, expected to collectively raise over ₹25,000 crore, include a mix of fresh equity issuances and offer for sale (OFS) component, merchant bankers said.

"With markets stabilising and investor sentiment improving, companies that were waiting on the sidelines are now moving ahead with their IPO plans," said Bhavesh Shah, managing director (MD) and head, investment banking at Equirus Capital.

Among the largest offerings, Zepto plans to raise up to ₹8,010 crore through a fresh issue, along with an OFS of up to 113.4 million equity shares.

Housing finance company Truhome has proposed a ₹3,000-crore IPO, comprising a fresh issue of up to ₹1,500 crore and an OFS of an equal amount.

Elevate Campuses intends to raise ₹2,550 crore through a fresh issue, while Shiprocket has filed for a ₹2,342.35-crore IPO, including a fresh issue of up to ₹1,100 crore and an OFS worth ₹1,242.35 crore. Other companies preparing to hit the capital markets include Innoviview India (up to ₹ 2,000 crore, entirely through OFS) and Milky Mist Dairy Food (₹1,553 crore).

Dhoot Transmission, ARCIL (Asset Reconstruction Company India Ltd), Ardee Industries, Gaja Alternative Asset Management, Rays of Belief, Hy-Tech Engineers, Shankesh Jewellers and Learnfluence Education are also planning to launch their maiden public offerings.

Among the largest offerings, Zepto plans to raise up to ₹8,010 crore through a fresh issue

The fresh pipeline comes amid sustained activity in the primary market, reflecting improving investor sentiment and healthy demand for new listings.

Market participants expect IPO activity to remain buoyant as companies look to capitalise on favourable fundraising conditions.

So far this year, 36 companies have launched their IPOs, including nine that hit the primary market this month. Moreover, Manipal Health Enterprises and Juniper Green Energy are set to open their public issues on 29 July and 30 July, respectively. MV Electrosystems is also scheduled to launch its IPO next week.

Looking ahead, Shah said the long-term outlook for India's IPO market remains strong despite periodic volatility.

Shriram Fin: oil clouds strong Q1

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Shriram Finance's impressive June quarter (Q1FY27) results alone may not be enough to prop up the stock, given its commercial vehicle (CV) financier tag, at least until crude oil prices stabilize.

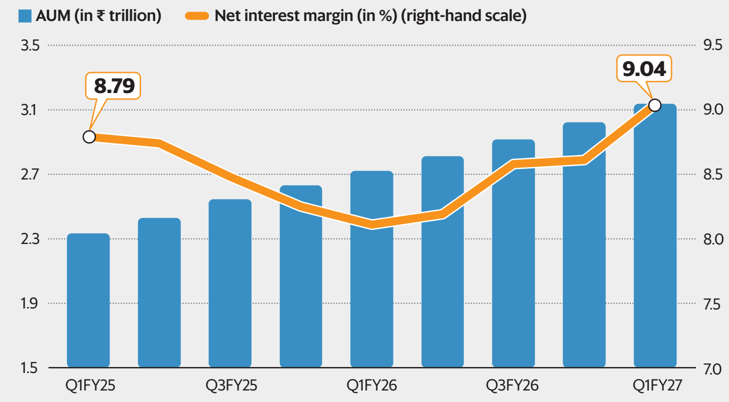
Shriram is the second largest non-banking financial company (NBFC) after Bajaj Finance in terms of market capitalization, and is viewed as a proxy play on commercial vehicles. Nearly 47% of its assets under management (AUM) is from the CV segment.

When crude oil prices climb, rising diesel costs squeeze the profits of commercial vehicle owners, unless freight rates rise to cushion the blow. This typically raises fears about their ability to repay loans, though no signs of stress have emerged so far, going by the June quarter results.

Shriram's net interest income (NII) surged 33.5% year-on-year to ₹7,706 crore. Management attributed a ₹500 crore boost in interest income to the ₹39,600 crore received from Japan's Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group (MUFG) in April for a 20% equity stake.

Robust show

Shriram Finance's Q1FY27 AUM grew by 15% year-on-year, and net interest margin jumped by 93 bps.



AUM is assets under management

Source: Company, PL Capital

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

However, the earnings call made no mention of the potential savings on interest costs following the retirement of roughly ₹18,000 crore in debt.

Nevertheless, even if the benefit of interest free equity funds were to be completely removed from interest income, net interest income growth would still have been healthy at 25% year-on-year. Similarly, core pre-provisioning operating profit would have grown nearly 33% year-on-year to ₹5,084 crore.

Shriram's management has maintained its outlook for assets under management, net interest margin (NIM) and credit cost (provision for bad debt). It has stuck to its guidance of 18% growth in assets under management for FY27.

It believes Q2FY27 could be slightly soft at 15%, similar to Q1FY27, with ongoing uncertainties around the West Asia conflict and the monsoon.

Management expects a stronger second half to make up for the slower growth in the first six months of FY27.

What explains the management's optimism that the AUM growth rate will pick up? Shriram's decision to finance more new vehicles should boost AUM as the cost difference between new and old is substantial. Also, about 150 new branches will be added in FY27, which is significant, given that the branch network has remained flat at 3,225 for the 12 months leading up to Q1FY27. While more branches and manpower would mean higher costs, management clarified it does not see the cost-income ratio rising materially from 25% for Q1FY27 as productivity at new branches increases.

TARGETS INTACT

SHRIRAM'S management has maintained its outlook for AUM, NIM and credit cost

IT expects a stronger second half to make up for the slower growth in the first six months of FY27

Net interest margin is expected to stabilize at 8.5% in the long term, even as it rose 93 bps year-on-year to 9.04% in Q1FY27, because Shriram intends to pass on the benefit of lower cost of funds to borrowers.

Shriram's credit cost-to-total assets ratio held steady at 1.66% in Q1FY27—virtually unchanged year-on-year, sequentially, and against the FY26 average—reflecting stable asset quality.

Management expects credit costs to remain below 2% for FY27 and over the medium term. This helps address a key perception issue: even a highly diversified lender like Bajaj Finance recorded a 1.9% credit cost in FY26. Shriram's numbers show that its commercial vehicle concentration hasn't led to unusually high risk.

Investors who are willing to take the risk of concentrated AUM will find Shriram's valuation relatively attractive. The stock is valued at 18 times estimated FY27 earnings based on a *Bloomberg* consensus estimate, versus 26 times for Bajaj Finance, which is generally seen as the benchmark.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Stop before it happens: cos ping law firms to prevent insider trading

Yash Tiwari & Apoorva Ajith
MUMBAI

Listed companies are increasingly seeking legal guidance not to defend insider trading investigations, but to prevent them from happening in the first place. Securities lawyers said the nature of client queries has shifted dramatically over the past few years, after the regulator tightened India's insider trading framework by leveraging technology.

Clients now want to know what qualifies as unpublished price sensitive information (UPSI), when confidential information should be recorded first, who inside the company should have access to it, how it should be shared with auditors, consultants and law firms, and what steps a board should take if it detects suspicious trading by an employee. Lawyers said many companies are also seeking advice on conducting internal investigations before the regulator steps in, and strengthening compliance systems to prevent lapses and avoid regulatory scrutiny.

UPSI includes upcoming financial results, mergers, or major business decisions that could move a company's stock price.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) has designed strict rules on UPSI to prevent insider trading and shield ordinary investors from market manipulation.

In 2018, the regulator ordered listed companies to build in-house structured digital databases (SDD) to track every instance of UPSI being shared. This digital log records who accessed the information, when, and with whom it was shared, creating an audit trail.

According to Sudhir Bassi, executive director at Khaitan & Co., companies frequently seek advice on when the information becomes UPSI, timing of the first entry in the SDD, subsequent updates to the database, legitimate ways of sharing confidential information, and the action that should be taken if an employee is suspected of insider trading.

Queries sent to Sebi remained unanswered.


Sebi has designed strict rules on UPSI to prevent insider trading. MINT

"Our recommendation is to move from checkbox compliance to proactive, documented governance by adopting a broad approach to identifying UPSI, automating SDD entries and maintaining robust internal controls. A well-documented compliance trail is as important as preventing the leak itself," said Gaurav Mistry, partner at DSK Legal.

The shift reflects the regulatory approach to insider trading, while keeping an eye on unusual price movement and trading activity. Investigations are now increasingly built around digital evidence, corporate records and internal governance rather than relying on circumstantial evidence.

Boards are also seeking guidance on whether trading windows should be closed for mergers, fundraising exercises and restructuring plans, and who should be classified as a 'designated person', and whether trades by promoters' relatives could attract scrutiny, said Milind Jha, partner at Dentons Link Legal.

"The SDD has been a game-changer... Sebi no longer builds the evidence; companies are required to build it for them," said Pulkit Sukhramani, partner at JSA Advocates & Solicitors.

In 2018, Sebi issued the SDD mandate under its insider trading rules, which took effect on 1 April 2019.

In July 2020, the regulator expanded the framework by adding intermediaries such as law firms, consultants, merchant bankers to the list of people to be tracked using SDD, as they also handle the UPSI of a company.

Investigations are now increasingly built around digital evidence, corporate records and internal governance

Instead of restricting trades in cases of insider trading, boards have now moved to investing in stronger governance systems.

"There has been a shift in the corporate psyche from reactive compliance to proactive governance infrastructure. Companies are investing heavily in compliance infrastructure, internal surveillance, access controls and training to prevent violations and demonstrate the adequacy of their internal processes in the event of regulatory scrutiny," said Rutu Gandhi, partner at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas.

Pulkit Sukhramani, partner at JSA Advocates and Solicitors said that companies are commissioning internal investigations as soon as they detect unusual trading because early action demonstrates a strong compliance culture and may help reduce regulatory exposure.

An inaccurate or incomplete SDD is also treated as an independent breach under Sebi's insider trading regulations, and not establishing SDD is considered a breach of rules. "The SDD often serves as the primary evidentiary record for tracing the dissemination of UPSI. While it is not conclusive proof of insider trading, it constitutes significant corroborative evidence when read with trading data, communication records and other material," said Yogesh Chande, partner at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co.

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For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com

'Markets may be driven by Q1 earnings growth, domestic liquidity'

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MUMBAI

INTERVIEW

The initial earnings data for Q1FY27 suggests corporate earnings are rebounding after a relatively subdued FY26, according to Anand Rathi, founder and chairman of the eponymous financial services group.

At the same time, geopolitical tensions have once again put crude oil prices in the spotlight. But historical trends suggest that while major conflicts often trigger sharp spikes in oil prices, those moves have typically proved temporary rather than structural, Rathi said in an interview with *Mint*.

Edited excerpts:

Which sectors are best insulated from a weaker rupee and higher forex volatility?

During periods of heightened forex volatility or a weaker rupee, export-oriented sectors tend to benefit from higher revenue realisation in rupee terms. These include IT, pharmaceuticals, textiles and specialty chemicals, where a significant share of revenues comes from overseas markets.

However, the overall benefit could be limited by ongoing geopolitical uncertainties and supply chain disruptions.

On the other hand, companies that rely heavily on imported raw materials, such as oil marketing companies and airlines, could face higher input costs, partly offsetting the benefits of a weaker rupee. As a result, while exporters remain relatively better positioned, the extent of the advantage is likely to be constrained by broader global uncertainties.

Could the Reserve Bank of India's FCNR measures provide a meaningful boost to private banks' profitability, or is the impact likely to be limited?

RBI recently announced concessional swap rates for FCNR(B) deposits until 30 September to attract more dollar inflows and strengthen foreign exchange reserves. As of 20 July, banks had mobilized nearly $20 billion under the scheme, indicating a healthy response from non-resident Indians.

That said, the direct impact on banks' profitability is likely to be limited. FCNR deposits still involve swap costs, while the funds are typically deployed at competitive lending rates, resulting in only a modest impact on net interest margins.

The bigger benefit lies on the liquidity side. Banks raising FCNR deposits can reduce their reliance on higher-cost domestic bulk deposits, marginally lowering their cost of funds.

The larger gains, however, are likely to be at the macroeconomic level. Higher foreign currency inflows support the rupee, improve macroeconomic stability, enhance liquidity and create a more favourable environment for credit growth. Over time, stronger credit demand, better asset quality and lower credit costs are likely to contribute more meaningfully to bank profitability than the FCNR scheme itself.

The earnings reported so far suggest growth has accelerated. What is your key takeaway from this earnings season?

The initial Q1FY27 earnings indicate that corporate earnings are recovering after a relatively subdued FY26.

So far, nearly half of the companies in the Nifty 50 and Nifty 100 have reported results, with earnings per share (EPS) growing about 6.6% year-on-year.

Among the roughly 20% of companies in the Nifty Midcap 150 and Smallcap 250 indices that have reported results so far, earnings have grown 11.3% and 52.7%, respectively.

Sector-wise, banks and financial services have posted healthy earnings growth of 18-20%, supported by steady credit growth and stable asset quality. The automobile sector has also reported strong earnings, driven by resilient domestic demand and rising premiumization. Oil and gas companies, however, have seen weaker earnings because of commodity price volatility, pricing pressures and an unfavourable base.

Do the risks from higher crude prices and energy shocks appear lower than initially feared? If so, what does that mean for corporate earnings?

Our historical analysis of crude oil prices during major geopolitical conflicts suggests that while prices often experience sharp short-term volatility, the impact has generally been temporary rather than structural.

During major global conflicts such as the Russia-Ukraine war, crude prices rose by around 35% from their lows before retreating over the following two to three months.

Similarly, during the recent US-Iran conflict, crude initially climbed sharply—from around $69 a barrel to nearly $115, but later eased back to the $70-80 range as tensions subsided.

Indian sectors such as automobiles, cement, chemicals, paints, aviation and consumer goods are particularly sensitive to crude oil prices.

Higher foreign currency inflows support the rupee, improve macroeconomic stability

Anand Rathi
Founder and chairman of Anand Rathi

What gaps do you see between the growth in Indian equity markets and other global markets?

India has been among the fastest-growing economies in recent years, recording GDP growth of 7-8%, and it continues to stand out among both emerging and developed markets. That provides a favourable backdrop for domestic equities.

The country is also supported by strong domestic consumption, rising private-sector capital expenditure, sustained government infrastructure spending and an expanding manufacturing base.

Corporate earnings are expected to continue growing at a healthy pace.

Unlike many export-led economies, India's growth is driven primarily by domestic demand, making it relatively more resilient to global slowdowns.

India's long-term performance has been consistently strong. Over the past decade, it has delivered annualized returns of 12-13%.

Small-cap stocks have outperformed large-caps this year. Will that continue?

Large-cap stocks have recently underperformed because of sustained foreign portfolio investor (FPI) outflows and weakness in the IT sector.

Small-cap earnings, meanwhile, have been more broad-based. Going forward, however, large-caps are expected to regain relative strength as foreign institutional investors return.

What could drive markets from here? What are the key risks?

Indian markets are likely to be driven by Q1FY27 earnings growth, strong domestic liquidity, policy support and a revival in foreign institutional inflows. The biggest near-term risk remains geopolitical tensions in West Asia, which could affect macroeconomic conditions, crude oil prices and foreign investor sentiment.

For an extended version of the interview, go to livemint.com

How MRF's promoter family stayed united for 80 years

MRF's discipline and efforts to stay out of the limelight minimized disputes and divisions

Ayaan Kartik & Varun Sood
NEW DELHI/BENGALURU

MRF Ltd's promoter group comprises 102 individuals—arguably the largest family shareholding base in any listed Indian company. Yet, remarkably, it has seen no public family disputes in the 80 years since its inception.

MRF, the country's largest tyremaker, published its annual report last week, which detailed the shareholding pattern of the promoter group, which owns 27.77% of the company at the end of June 2026. Thirteen promoter entities own about 16% of the shares, while the 102 individual family members own the remaining nearly 12%.

So, what makes MRF founder K.M. Mammen Mappillai's family work harmoniously with other family members, who own the *Malayala Manorama* newspaper, and many of whom are third-generation scions?

Academics and investors say the company's disciplined approach and conscious effort to stay out of the limelight have helped minimize disputes and internal divisions—issues that have plagued several prominent business families, including the Murugappa, Bajaj and Reliance groups, and more recently surfaced within the Kirloskar Group, Godfrey Phillips, and between Bharat Forge chairman Baba Kalyani and sister Sugandha Hiremath.

MRF shuns media interactions, and the company did not reply to a *Mint* questionnaire. At least three investors and two former independent directors declined to speak about the company, while a few agreed to speak on condition of anonymity.

"I am not in a position to talk much about them. They are a closed group and don't like being discussed. I will honour that principle and their trust," said a Mumbai-based investor who owns more than 1% of the company.

Thirteen promoter entities own about 16% of the shares.

Members of the Mammen family hold operational roles while the other family members own shares of MRF.

"Distribution of shares across family members ensures that ownership is not concentrated in an individual or a specific branch while accommodating the interests of all family branches," Kavil Ramachandran, former family business and entrepreneurship professor and senior advisor at Thomas Schmidheiny Centre for Family Enterprise at the Indian School of Business, said.

"Maintaining a low profile in public is strategic to minimize the creation of silos and power centres within the family. They consider ownership as a responsibility to create and preserve wealth across generations. The family has been known for such discipline, which has helped them stay together and avoid divisions of business," Ramachandran said.

"All the branches of the family hold at least one family council meeting annually to discuss all the matters. While it's not clear whether their constitution is on paper, they do follow a set of rules and ethics to guide their conduct," one of the executives cited earlier said.

To understand how the shareholding has been divided among the family, it is first important to look at how the family is branched. Kandathil Varghese Mappillai founded *Malayala Manorama* in 1888 in Kottayam, Kerala. His nephew K.C. Mammen Mappillai took charge after Varghese Mappillai's demise.

K.C. Mammen Mappillai had eight sons and a daughter, which branched out the Malayala Manorama family. One of his sons, K.M. Mammen Mappillai, went on to start MRF as a toy balloon manufacturing unit in Chennai (then known as Madras) in 1946, and within 15 years the company began making tyres after a collaboration with US-based Mansfield Tyre and Rubber.

It went public in 1961 and, owing to its tightly held share base, now has the highest-priced individual stock in India, trading at around ₹130,000 per share.

K.M. Mammen Mappillai, who passed away in 2003, had three sons, K.M. Mammen, Ravi Mammen, and Arun Mammen and a daughter, Ramani Joseph.

While Ravi Mammen passed away in 1990, the two sons, K.M. Mammen and Arun Mammen, helm the board as chairman and vice chairman, respectively, today. Ramani Joseph is on the board of other group companies, including Coastal Rubber Equipment Pvt. Ltd.

"Ownership is typically concentrated among a smaller number of individuals or family branches headed by a patriarch. The MRF ownership structure is noteworthy because it appears to have retained a broad family ownership base over time," said Varsha Khattri, associate professor of marketing at Delhi-based FORE School of Management.

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PEACEFUL PROMOTERS

MRF'S 102-strong promoter group is the largest family shareholding in any listed Indian firm

THE MRF promoter group owned 27.77% of the company at the end of June 2026

MEMBERS of the Mammen family hold operational roles within the company

ALL branches of the family hold at least one family council meeting annually to discuss all matters

Jindal Steel acknowledges top brass churn, bets on new hires

Dipali Banka & Nehal Chaliawala
MUMBAI

Jindal Steel Ltd's new managing director (MD), Vidya Rattan Sharma, acknowledged that frequent top-management exits at the Naveen Jindal-led company have become a cause of concern and reassured investors that the latest management overhaul will not derail strategic continuity.

In an investor call on Saturday, Sharma sought to shift the focus from the handful of top executives to what he described as the company's "upper middle management force" of nearly 1,800-2,000 managers, vice presidents and general managers.

He credited these people for being the driving force behind the company's operations. "We have a very strong upper middle and also senior management team, up to the vice president level. We don't find any movement there," he said.

"As far as the movement of senior persons, yes, it is always an area of concern. We must see why the people take a change or move," he added, vowing to "put full effort" to ensure "people stay longer".

To steady the ship, the listed company has fallen back on old hands, with at least half a dozen executives, including Sharma, returning to senior positions after stints at Jindal's private steel business in Oman and the Czech Republic.

The other executives include the head of the rolling mills business at Raigarh, the head of steel melting at the company's Angul plant, the legal head, as well as mid- to senior-level executives in finance and taxation, according to an executive.

More executives are likely to be called upon in the coming days, this person said.

Roopali Mehra, the new head of sales and marketing, has also returned to the company, having left in 2016.

"The Jindal Group has people at various locations. If need be, we can call them. We also send people from India overseas. That's the beauty of a large group," the executive said on condition of anonymity.

The reshuffle marks one of the most significant management overhauls at Jindal Steel in recent years

The board of India's fourth-largest steelmaker has brought in half a dozen other senior executives as part of a management revamp, including new leaders for finance, operations and human resources, Sharma said in the investor call. The executives have been drawn from across the steel industry.

Among the key hires is Rajiv Kumar, who has joined as chief operating officer (COO) after a long stint at Tata Steel Ltd. He was most recently the chief executive officer (CEO) of Vedanta's Aluminium business. Sandeep Modi has been appointed as the chief financial officer, having previously served as the chief financial officer (CFO) of Hindustan Zinc Ltd.

It has also brought in Biju Nair from ArcelorMittal, as well as senior leaders from its businesses in Oman and the Czech Republic.

The international business had most recently been involved in talks to acquire a stake in Thyssenkrupp Steel Europe, but the negotiations were mutually called off on 2 May after months of due diligence because of disagreements over pension liabilities, high European energy costs and the scale of future investments required.

Jindal Steel did not immediately respond to *Mint*'s emailed queries.

The reshuffle marks one of the most significant management overhauls at Jindal Steel in recent years and follows a period of unusual churn at the top. Since Sharma stepped down as managing director in 2022, none of his successors completed a full term, raising concerns among analysts about leadership stability at a time when the company is pursuing ambitious capacity expansion plans.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.


Jindal Steel's new MD, Vidya Rattan Sharma, acknowledged that top-management exits have become a cause of concern.

'Trace all insurance sales to cull misselling'

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Misselling remains one of the insurance industry's biggest challenges, and tackling it will require holding individual salespeople—not just intermediaries—accountable, Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) chairman Ajay Seth said on Saturday.

Speaking at the silver jubilee conclave of the Insurance Brokers Association of India (Ibai) in New Delhi, Seth said insurers should be able to trace every policy back to the individual point of sales person (Posp), agent or salesperson who sold it. "At present, such a database does not exist."

Currently, in bancassurance and broker-led sales, insurers typically identify only the intermediary, such as a bank or insurance broker, and not the individual who advised the customer and sold the policy.

"This gap would be addressed through the proposed Public Insurance Registry, which is being developed to improve transparency and accountability across the insurance distribution chain. Once it is in place, it can help tackle misselling," Seth told *Mint* on the sidelines of the event.

He said insurers must also scrutinize customer complaints more closely to identify where failures occur.

"Identify who went wrong in the system. I accept that not every grievance will be genuine. But if a complaint is found to be genuine, those responsible must be held accountable. Hire Posps with due diligence because they are the ones interacting with customers. When they change jobs, their history should be visible," Seth said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Wipro, Murugappa chase food brand Double Horse

FROM PAGE 1

Manjilas is among Kerala's oldest packaged food firms. MINT

A Manjilas spokesperson said the company is "open to exploring strategic opportunities that can strengthen our business and accelerate growth," but declined to comment on the sale. Manjilas reported revenue of ₹341.5 crore in FY25, up 8% year-on-year, but slipped to a net loss of ₹4 crore, compared with a net profit of ₹90 lakh in FY24.

EY did not respond to emailed queries, while Wipro Consumer declined to comment.

EID Parry India Ltd, the Murugappa Group's listed food and agribusiness company, said it "continuously evaluates various strategic opportunities in the ordinary course of business for growth and expansion." It added that so far, there is no event or information that requires mandatory disclosure by the company, and that it would make disclosures if required.

Large consumer companies are increasingly buying out established packaged food brands. In 2020, Norway's Orkla acquired a majority stake in Kerala-based Eastern Condiments, before buying out its minority shareholders. Reliance Consumer Products entered the category by acquiring Southern Health Foods, owner of the Manna brand, while Wipro bought Nirapara and Brahmins.

The development reflects the ongoing consolidation in India's regional packaged foods industry

EID Parry sells Parry's-branded including sugar, packaged rice, millets, dals, sweeteners and value-added sugar products. In FY26, it reported consolidated revenue of ₹38,534 crore, up 21.9% year-on-year, while consolidated net profit declined 22.1% to ₹1,380 crore.

Wipro Consumer is accelerating its expansion through acquisitions. On Thursday, it agreed to acquire TTK Healthcare's Eva and Good Home brands for ₹256 crore, while earlier in the week, it agreed to acquire Philippine personal care company S Brands Consumer Care Inc. If completed, the Double Horse acquisition would be its 18th acquisition globally.

After announcing the acquisition of Eva and Good Home brands, Wipro Consumer CEO Kumar Chander told reporters that his company plans to "double down" on food in India. While the company would continue to grow organically, "if there are good acquisitions that make sense for us, then this will also be considered in our strategy," said Chander, also managing director of Wipro Enterprises.

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RuPay credit on UPI rises, but profits remain elusive

For issuers, zero MDR makes sense only if the card generates enough downstream revenue

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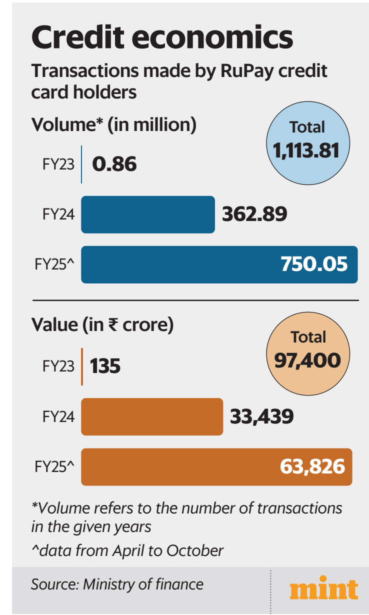
RuPay credit cards on Unified Payments Interface (UPI) have cracked one of digital payments' trickiest challenges—turning credit cards into an everyday payment tool. But their use for mostly low-value transactions has presented a new challenge for banks and fintech companies: higher engagement without a clear path to profitability.

RuPay credit cards linked to UPI account for nearly four in every 10 credit card transactions, but just about 8% of spending, according to a Bernstein estimate cited by *Mint* in October 2025. RuPay credit card holders made 750 million transactions worth ₹63,825.8 crore in April-October 2024-25, showed the latest available Union finance ministry data.

RuPay credit card holders made 750 million transactions worth ₹63,825.8 crore in April-October 2024-25. MINT



GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Siddharth Mehta, co-founder of fintech Kiwi, said credit-on-UPI is already changing the way cards are used, with customers transacting more than 20 times a month, versus four or five times for a normal card. He said the average ticket size is lower, but monthly spend per user still stays in the ₹15,000 to ₹20,000 range because frequency offsets the smaller ticket sizes.

Low-value credit-on-UPI transactions are not inherently damaging, but they can become operationally expensive at scale because even a small per-transaction vendor fee adds up over millions of transactions, explained Ramanathan R.V., co-founder of credit cards-as-a-service (CCaaS) platform Hyperface.

"Banks typically pay 25 to 50 paise to the core card vendor for each transaction, so if customers start using the card for ₹50 or ₹100-rupee payments daily, then the economics get squeezed even before the issuer has had time to monetize the account," added Ramanathan.

Credit on UPI took off after the Reserve Bank of India nod in June 2022, beginning with RuPay cards. UPI's zero-merchant discount rate (MDR) regime had already accelerated QR code payments, while the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) provided for a nil MDR on RuPay credit card transactions of up to ₹2,000 at eligible small offline merchants, helping spur adoption.

Zero MDR—the fee a merchant pays to accept a digital payment—on most UPI transactions keeps costs low for users but squeezes the revenue of banks, fintechs, payment processors and card networks that build and maintain the ecosystem.

The NPCI has also been nudging adoption with issuer incentives. Industry estimates reported by *Mint* in July 2025 showed that the digital payment facilitator now pays banks 10 to 12 basis points on the transaction value, depending on volume.

For example, on a ₹100 RuPay credit-on-UPI payment, the merchant usually pays nothing, but the issuer bank still bears a small operating cost, including vendor fees and backend processing expenses.

For a conventional Mastercard or Visa credit-card swipe, the merchant typically pays a card MDR of about 2% to 3%; so on ₹100, the fee is roughly ₹2 to ₹3. That fee is then split among the issuing bank, acquiring bank, card network and the payment processor; the issuer gets the largest share because it provides the credit line and absorbs repayment risk.

Since card issuers still earn through interchange, interest, annual fees, late-payment charges, equated monthly instalment (EMI) conversion fees and cross-selling loans or insurance, the real challenge is not the transaction alone but whether the account matures into a profitable customer relationship.

In that sense, zero MDR can be absorbed only if the card starts generating enough downstream revenue to offset the thin economics of frequent small-ticket usage.

StillRuPay's biggest advantage over Visa and Mastercard is that it is currently the only credit card network that can be linked to UPI, allowing banks to extend credit card acceptance to millions of QR-code merchants beyond the conventional card infrastructure.

In practice, this has made RuPay credit cards a way for banks to acquire new customers and keep existing ones using their cards more often. Banks can offer customers access to another card network, while fintechs leverage their large user bases to issue more cards and encourage regular spending.

Ramanathan of Hyperface said banks are not loyal to any one network because they respond to incentives and to the need to offer customers choice. In his experience, RuPay is closing in on Mastercard and Visa fast among new credit card customers.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

CARD GAMES

CREDIT-on-UPI is changing the way cards are used, with people transacting over 20x a month

LOW-value credit-on-UPI transactions can become operationally expensive at scale

EVEN a small per-transaction vendor fee adds up over millions of transactions

CREDIT on UPI took off after the Reserve Bank of India nod in June 2022, beginning with RuPay cards

Sarvjit Singh Samra, MD and CEO, Capital SFB.

Capital SFB nears metric to apply for universal bank licence

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Punjab-based Capital Small Finance Bank has moved closer to meeting the eligibility criteria to seek a universal banking licence. Its net non-performing assets (NPAs) dropped to 1.14% in the June quarter, narrowing the gap on what management called the single remaining pending requirement before seeking an upgrade. However, the bank's board will decide on submitting a formal application only by FY29.

"From a tickbox perspective, we were left with one tickbox, that is a net NPA," managing director and chief executive Sarvjit Singh Samra said in an interview, referring to the RBI's threshold of 1% or lower for the previous two fiscal years. He added that the metric has steadily improved from 1.38% in the September quarter.

The bank reported a 29% year-on-year rise in June-quarter net profit to ₹41 crore, supported by 22% growth in net interest income to ₹134 crore and a 23% increase in pre-provision operating profit to ₹65 crore.

While small finance banks must give 60% of their total loans to the priority sector, universal banks have a lower mandate of 40%, allowing them to lend more freely.

Under RBI norms, small finance banks seeking to convert to universal banks need to meet several criteria. They must be listed; have a minimum net worth of ₹1,000 crore at the end of the previous quarter; be profitable in the previous two financial years; and have maximum gross NPAs and net NPAs of up to 3% and 1%, respectively, in the previous two fiscal years.

So far, AU Small Finance Bank is the only one to have received RBI approval to upgrade to a universal bank. Applications by Jana Small Finance Bank and Ujjivan Small Finance Bank were 'returned' by the regulator.

"The decision [to submit the application] will be taken by our apex board," Samra said, tying the timing to two milestones: having more than 300 branches, and a ₹16,000-crore loan book. The bank had ₹9,074 crore in gross advances and 216 branches as of 30 June.

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AI intensifies pricing war among IT services firms

FROM PAGE 1

The impact on profitability has been uneven across firms. MINT

productivity gains reduce the amount clients are willing to pay for the same work.

Rather than hiring aggressively, companies are cushioning the impact of the pricing war by deploying more employees already on the bench, which is helping offset lower billing rates, according to Namratha Dharshan, chief business leader at Connecticut-based IT research and advisory firm ISG.

"AI is definitely increasing pricing pressure between IT services companies because internally, companies are restructuring and macro pressures are forcing companies to keep costs low," Dharshan said, adding that Tata Consultancy Services's (TCS) layoffs last year were conducted to do away with talent that could not be reskilled and upskilled.

Srini Pallia, CEO of Wipro, said pricing is also being impacted by how clients want to implement AI—over a shorter period of time or spread out over the tenure of a deal.

"When you deploy AI quickly, the token costs also increase for our client. So, they are looking at the total cost of ownership. And that is something that we've been carefully working on," Pallia said during the company's post-earnings analyst call on 16 July.

The type of projects being offered is also impacting margins and competition, Pallia said: "If it is a new, reimagine-AI kind of project and program, the margins are much better. But if it's a traditional work where you have to bring in the productivity (benefits) through AI and at the same time help the clients to shift the budgets, there are competitive pressures."

Tech Mahindra chief executive Mohit Joshi acknowledged growing pressure to promise aggressive AI-driven productivity gains in order to win long-term contracts, but said his company is refraining from engaging in major price cuts.

Committing to productivity improvements of 70-80% in five- to seven-year deals would mean "getting into productivity benefits that are not visible today without very significant process or system changes by the client, so that is where we would hold back", Joshi said during the company's post-earnings analyst call on 16 July.

The impact on profitability, however, has been uneven across companies. Wipro's margins fell 130 basis points sequentially to 16%, which was the steepest fall among the top five with TCS. On the other hand, Tech Mahindra's operating margins jumped 60 basis points to 14.4%, which was the biggest jump among the big five in the April-June quarter.

Infosys chief financial officer Jayesh Sanghrajka said demands for higher productivity and aggressive pricing had weighed on the company's outlook, prompting it to trim its revenue guidance at the upper end.

Artificial intelligence is also lowering barriers for mid-sized IT companies to compete for large contracts

The ask of productivity from clients and increased competitiveness—competition in pricing that reflected in a lower-than-expected pricing this quarter—will have an effect on the rest of the year," Sanghrajka said during the company's post-earnings analyst call on 23 July.

Infosys cut the upper end of its guidance from the preceding quarter and now expects to end the full year with 1.5-3% growth in constant currency terms.

AI is also lowering barriers for mid-sized IT companies to compete for large contracts, intensifying pricing pressure on bigger rivals.

"The large caps will have pressure from the smaller peers because a mid-sized IT firm is also competing aggressively be it pricing or offering—to bag large deals—whereas sometimes a larger company may not be able to due to higher cost pressures and lesser agile teams," said Dharshan, adding that the focus on mid-market companies is shifting this dynamic.

Still, some tech services firms are focusing on not ceding profitability as the new technology rewrites how they engage with clients. "I feel that we continue to remain disciplined in terms of our pricing, and so that gives us the optionality in the future about how much we want to focus on expanding margins and how much we want to focus on further deepening capabilities," said Joshi.

Rural fintech credit mostly untouched

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Despite India emerging as the world's third-largest fintech ecosystem and rapidly expanding its digital public infrastructure, rural adoption of fintech credit remains negligible. Less than 2% of rural households reported borrowing from fintech entities, according to a study by the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (Nabard).

Less than 2% rural households took credit from fintechs. MINT

The report noted that while banks have expanded digital banking infrastructure and the government has built robust digital public infrastructure, the expected breakthrough in last-mile financial inclusion through fintech-led credit has yet to materialize.

Instead, rural households reported greater awareness and usage of digital services offered through Primary Agricultural Credit Societies (PACS) functioning as Common Service Centres (CSCs). The findings suggest that trusted local institutions continue to play a far greater role in rural financial services.

Last August, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman, speaking at the Digital Payments Awards 2025 said India's fintech market is projected to grow to over $400 billion by 2028-29.

Queries sent to the ministries of finance and rural development, Nabard, the Reserve Bank of India and the Fintech Association for Consumer Empowerment went unanswered.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Apple's India iPhone boom hits first speed bump in four years

FROM PAGE 1

all smartphone sales in 2026, potentially making this the weakest year for the ₹43-billion market since before the pandemic.

Apple's supply constraints could also weigh on its India performance this year, even as demand for premium smartphones remains intact.

"Apple is likely to see a decline in device shipments during the June quarter. For the full year, Apple's sales will likely either remain flat or see a marginal growth—far slower than the way Apple has grown over the past few years. More than any other reason, this is because the supply of the iPhone 17 is very restricted—and even when Apple accommodates the rise in memory chip costs, an immediate resolution is unlikely—perhaps until as long as 2028," said Navkendar Singh, associate vice-president at IDC India.

According to Singh, supplies of the iPhone 17 have remained constrained as memory chip suppliers renegotiate prices with Apple, slowing the company's ability to normalize shipments.

"As chips get costlier, most vendors in the supply chain will renegotiate prices to ensure they make the most of the higher prices even as the market normalizes by 2028. This renegotiation will take its due course of time, and in the meantime restrict supplies of the iPhone 17," Singh added.

Three retailers in Delhi, Kolkata and Mumbai that *Mint* spoke with, each of whom requested anonymity citing non-disclosure agreements with Apple, said availability of Apple's base iPhone 17 model remains limited and that they expect price revisions soon.

"Typically, Apple reduces the price of the outgoing iPhone by about ₹10,000 as they launch a new one. This year, we're expecting a considerably different iPhone 18 lineup—and no such price reductions that fuel additional demand in September," one of the retailers said.

The setback comes as Apple is leaning increasingly on India as a growth market. BLOOMBERG

Queries emailed to Apple India went unanswered.

"The supply crunch for Apple's iPhone 17 has been persistent since the lineup launched in September last year, and continues to hit retailers across the country. A nominal price hike, especially for iPhones, is not that big a concern to be honest, since other brands have increased prices, consumers are happy to pay a small premium if they can get their hands on the iPhone 17," said Manish Khatri, partner at Mumbai-based retailer, Mahesh Telecom.

Analysts do not see demand for iPhones shrinking.

Tarun Pathak, director of research at Counterpoint, said the demand is seen steady this year.

"Buyers of premium smartphones have continued to keep the iPhone on their radar, with other brands such as Samsung increasing prices due to memory chip cost pressures. Apple is very likely to finish the year in the top five brands list, but the quarterly record streak could take a hit due to disruptions right now," Pathak said.

INDIA FOCUS

ON 30 April, Apple's Tim Cook said India's performance had left him 'over the moon excited'

APPLE has so far shielded the iPhone from price increases, although it warned that may not last

IDC India and Counterpoint expect Apple to sell 15 million iPhones this calendar year, up from 14 million in 2025 but marking a sharp slowdown from the rapid growth the company has enjoyed in recent years.

Over the past eight years, Apple has expanded iPhone sales tenfold, growing at 33%a year since 2019.

The broader market, however, is moving in the opposite way. IDC and Counterpoint expect smartphone shipments in India to fall by as much as 15% in 2026 to about 130 million units, lowest since 2018.

This has been building up since India's smartphone market peaked at 161 million units in 2021. Analysts attribute the decline to longer replacement cycles, limited hardware innovation, inflation and macro uncertainties. This year, higher supply chain and manufacturing costs may add pressure by pushing up prices.

Luxury boom lifts India into Swiss watchmakers' top 15

The country imported 200,000 Swiss watches in the first six months of 2026

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As the Swiss watch industry's global exports soften, India is emerging as one of its brightest markets, fuelled by first-time luxury buyers, expanding premium retail and lower trade barriers.

When Swiss watchmakers reviewed the first half of 2026, India stood out for more than just growth. The country imported 200,000 Swiss watches in the first six months of 2026, up nearly 37% from a year earlier, while the value of those imports rose more than 31% to 168.7 million Swiss francs (about ₹1,991 crore), according to the Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry (FH). The gains lifted India to become the world's 15th-largest export market up from 21st a year earlier, even as the industry's global exports by volume fell 0.7%.

Unlike mature luxury markets, where growth increasingly depends on replacement purchases, India's market is expanding because more consumers are buying their first luxury watch, while premium retail is expanding and global brands are bringing higher-priced collections into the country, industry executives said.

"India's growth is driven by increased demand, resulting from the rising purchasing power of the middle class and rising wealth. The entry into force of the free trade agreement between Switzerland and India last October has also contributed to this," Philippe Pegoraro, chief economist at the Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry, told *Mint*.

India, along with France, was among the standout performers. France posted 63.4% growth in value terms, while most other major markets recorded single-digit growth, with Mexico and Poland delivering low double-digit increases.

One catalyst has been the India-Switzerland Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA), which came into force in October 2025 and is expected to gradually reduce tariffs on Swiss watches over the coming years.

Higher prices, however, also inflated import values. The Swiss franc strengthened against most currencies, including the rupee, while soaring gold prices and higher freight costs stemming from the West Asia conflict pushed up production costs. "The depreciation of the Indian rupee, the cost escalation of precious materials used in watches and the increase in the market size have all contributed to the gains. Despite that, business heads here said there is volume growth. Certain brands are doing very well," said Ashok Goel, managing director of Delhi-based listed firm Luxury Time Ltd, which distributes brands such as Hublot and TAG Heuer.

Ethos, one of India's largest luxury watch retailers, crossed the 100-store milestone in FY26. ISTOCKPHOTO

CLOCKING IN

FRANCE posted 63.4% growth in value terms, and was also a standout performer

THE Swiss franc strengthened against most currencies, as import value increased

INDUSTRY experts said watches priced above ₹10 lakh remain the fastest-growing segment

IN April, TAG Heuer said it expects India to become its largest market across the MEIAT region

He said shipments of the brands his company represents have grown by around 10-12%, suggesting that while higher prices inflated import values, demand has also remained healthy.

"There was a 10-24% appreciation in precious metal prices, which also impacted watch prices. But India will continue to grow," he added.

The strongest momentum is at the top end of the market. Executives said watches priced above ₹10 lakh remain the fastest-growing segment, while the ₹5-10 lakh category is also seeing healthy growth in value and volume.

Mall developers and retailers say watches have become one of the best-performing luxury categories, supported by growing interest from consumers who increasingly view them as investment purchases.

"Watches have been growing resiliently. People see them as appreciating assets and the second-hand market is robust too. They're being seen as both fashion purchases and value-accretive assets. We're seeing double-digit growth in both luxury and premium watches, with stronger double-digit growth in the luxury segment. More premium brands are expanding. Newer retail projects are attracting luxury watch retailers, reflecting continued premiumisation," said Pushpa Bector, group executive director and business head of DLF Retail.

Raahuul Kapoor, co-founder of Delhi-based luxury consultancy Luxury Ampersand Frolics, said the market's evolution is also reflected in a broader assortment of products. "Demand is up. It has also gone up because consumers today have access to many more expensive watches than ever before," Kapoor said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Corporate bill may ease tax burden for Category III AIFs

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MUMBAI

The Corporate Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, could give Category III alternative investment funds (AIFs) a tax-efficient alternative by allowing them to convert from trusts into limited liability partnerships (LLPs), potentially lowering tax costs and easing long-standing structural hurdles.

The amendments, introduced in Parliament and now before a Joint Parliamentary Committee, would for the first time allow specified trusts regulated by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to convert into LLPs.

AIFs invest in alternative assets such as private equity, hedge funds and other non-traditional investments beyond traditional stocks and bonds, with wealthy individuals and institutions as their main investors. There are three categories of AIFs in the country, with Category III AIFs focusing on high-risk, high-return trading strategies using leverage.

Category III AIFs don't enjoy tax pass-through status and are taxed at the fund level, which means that these funds pay tax before distributing proceeds to investors. The tax burden can be as high as 39%, compared with Category I and II AIFs, where long-term capital gains are taxed at 12.5% and short-term gains at 20%.

AIFs invest in alternative assets such as private equity. MINT

"It is pertinent to note that even a determinate trust may attract the maximum marginal rate on business income, whereas an LLP is assessed at a rate of 30%, representing a rate advantage for funds with significant business income," said S.R. Patnaik, partner (head - taxation) at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas. The effective tax rate for an LLP is 35%.

The high taxation stems from a 2014 circular by the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT). It said that if a trust deed did not identify beneficiaries and their beneficial interests, the trust could be treated as indeterminate and taxed at the maximum marginal rate (MMR). A determinate trust would specify its investors at the time of incorporation.

Category III AIFs raised commitments worth ₹3.15 trillion as of March, 2026, according to Sebi.

The circular also said that even determinate trusts earning business income would continue to be taxed at the maximum marginal rate. The clarification created a structural problem because AIFs may not be able to determine all beneficiaries at inception.

MMR is the highest tax rate that applies to a taxpayer's last rupee of income earned. For fiscal year 2026 under the new tax regime, the maximum marginal tax rate can reach 39% (30% base tax + 25% surcharge + 4% cess) for income exceeding ₹2 crore, representing the highest effective tax burden on the top slab.

The move from MMR to LLP taxation could lead to an arbitrage of over 3-5%, experts said. Sameer Gupta, national tax leader at EY India, said Category III AIFs pursuing long-short strategies had historically preferred LLPs where possible because of the lower tax incidence and greater certainty.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

JUBILANT FOODWORKS LIMITED

CIN: L74899UP1995PLC043677

Regd. Office: Plot No. 1A, Sector -16A, Noida – 201301, Uttar Pradesh

Corporate Office: 15th Floor, Tower-E, Skymark One, Plot No. H-10/A, Sector - 98, Noida – 201301, Uttar Pradesh

Tel: +91-120-6927500; +91-120-6935400

Website: www.jubilantfoodworks.com, **E-mail:** investor@jublfood.com

NOTICE OF THE 31ST ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING TO BE HELD THROUGH VIDEO CONFERENCING/OTHER AUDIO VISUAL MEANS, RECORD DATE AND DIVIDEND INFORMATION

NOTICE is hereby given that the **Thirty First (31st) Annual General Meeting ('AGM')** of the Members of **Jubilant FoodWorks Limited ('Company')** will be held on **Thursday, August 27, 2026** at **11.00 a.m. (IST)** through **Video Conferencing/Other Audio Visual Means ('VC/OAVM')**, in compliance with applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ('Act') and SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ('Listing Regulations') and circulars issued thereunder, to transact the business(es) as set out in the Notice convening the 31st AGM ('AGM Notice'). Members attending the AGM through VC/OAVM shall be reckoned for the purpose of quorum under Section 103 of the Act.

Electronic dissemination of AGM Notice & Annual Report: AGM Notice along with the Integrated Annual Report for FY 2025-26 ('Annual Report') will be sent in due course only through electronic mode to those Members whose email IDs are registered with the Company/Registrar to an Issue and Share Transfer Agent ('RTA')/Depository Participants ('DPs'). Additionally, in accordance with Regulation 36(1)(b) of the Listing Regulations, the Company will also be sending a letter providing the weblink, including the exact path of Annual Report to those shareholders whose email address is not registered with the Company/DPs. The aforesaid documents will also be available on the Company's website at https://www.jubilantfoodworks.com, websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and National Stock Exchange Limited at www.nseindia.com.

E-Voting: Members will be provided with the facility to cast their vote electronically, through the remote e-Voting facility (prior to AGM) and e-Voting facility (during the AGM), on all the resolutions set forth in the AGM Notice. The detailed procedure for remote e-Voting and e-Voting facility will be provided in the AGM Notice. Facility for e-Voting during the AGM will be made available to those Members present in the AGM through VC/OAVM facility and have not cast their vote on the resolutions through remote e-Voting. The Members who have cast their vote by remote e-Voting prior to AGM may also attend/participate in the AGM through VC/OAVM but shall not be eligible to vote at the AGM. Members holding shares in physical form or Members whose email ID is not registered, may refer to the detailed procedure outlined in the AGM Notice for registration of email ID, procuring User ID and Password for attendance and e-Voting prior or during the AGM.

Dividend and Record Date: The Board of Directors of the Company at its meeting held on May 20, 2026 recommended a dividend of ₹1.20/- (i.e. 60%) per fully paid-up equity share of ₹2/- each for FY 2025-26 subject to approval of Members at the AGM. The dividend, upon approval by the Members, will be paid/dispatched to Members holding equity shares of the Company, either in electronic or in physical form as on the record date, i.e. July 17, 2026 for determining eligibility of Members to receive the dividend. Members are requested to update their Bank details as per instructions provided in the AGM Notice to receive electronic credit of their dividend entitlement.

Tax Deducted at Source ('TDS') on Dividend: Pursuant to the relevant provisions of Income Tax Act, 2025 read with the provisions of the Finance Act, 2020 ('IT Act'), dividend income is taxable in the hands of the Members and the Company is required to deduct tax at source from dividend paid to Members at the prescribed rate under the IT Act. The deduction of tax at source will be based on the residential status, category of Members and subject to fulfilment of conditions as provided under the IT Act. The Members are therefore, requested to upload requisite tax related documents/declarations on the link https://web.in.mpms.mufg.com/formsreg/submission-of-Form-121-41.html on or before **August 06, 2026** to enable the Company to determine the appropriate withholding tax rate applicable.

Members who wish to register/update their email IDs & Bank Account mandate may follow the below instructions:

- Members holding equity shares of the Company in demat form are requested to approach their respective DP and follow the process advised by DP.
- Members holding equity shares of the Company in physical form may submit the details in prescribed Form ISR-1 and other relevant Forms with Company's RTA, MUFG Intime India Pvt. Ltd (Formerly Link Intime India Pvt. Ltd.). Members may download the prescribed Forms from the Company's website at https://www.jubilantfoodworks.com/investors-shareholder-information-investor-forms.

For **Jubilant FoodWorks Limited**
Sd/-
(Mona Aggarwal)
Company Secretary

Date: 24.07.2026
Place: Noida

INDUS TOWERS LIMITED

indus TOWERS

CIN: L64201HR2006PLC073821

Regd. Office: Building No. 10, Tower A, 4th Floor, DLF Cyber City, Gurugram-122002, Haryana

Tel: +91-124-4296766, **Fax:** +91-124-4289333

Email id: compliance.officer@industowers.com **Website:** www.industowers.com

INFORMATION REGARDING 20th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING OF INDUS TOWERS LIMITED

The 20th Annual General Meeting **('AGM')** of Indus Towers Limited **('Company')** will be held through Video Conferencing ('VC')/ Other Audio Visual Means ('OAVM') on Wednesday, August 19, 2026 at 2:30 P.M. (IST) to transact the businesses as set forth in the Notice of AGM, in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013, Rules made thereunder and the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and in accordance with applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs **('MCA')** and Securities and Exchange Board of India **('SEBI')**.

In accordance with the applicable circulars, the Notice and Integrated Annual Report 2025-26 inter-alia covering Financial Statements 2025-26 **('Integrated Report')** will be sent through electronic mode to those Members whose email addresses are registered with the Company/ Depository Participants **('DPs')** as on Friday, July 24, 2026 and a physical communication is being sent to the Members whose email addresses are not updated in the records, which shall contain the exact link and QR code of the Company's website to access the Notice, Integrated Report and other relevant documents. The hard copy of the full Integrated Report will be sent those shareholders who will request for the same. The Notice and Integrated Report will also be available on the website of the Company at https://www.industowers.com/ on the website of National Securities Depository Limited ('NSDL') at www.evoting.nsdl.com and on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively. Further, the Members can join and participate in the AGM through VC/ OAVM facility only. The instructions for joining and manner of participation in the AGM will be provided in the Notice. Members attending AGM through VC/ OAVM shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.

The Members holding shares in physical form who have not registered their email address with the Company are requested to register the same by following the procedure specified in the Notice, i.e. through submitting the requisite Form ISR-1 along with the supporting documents. Form ISR-1 is available at https://ris.Kfintech.com/clientservices/isc/default.aspx and www.industowers.com and detailed FAQs on the same are available at https://ris.Kfintech.com/faq.html. The Members holding shares in dematerialized form are requested to register/ update their email addresses with their relevant DPs.

The Company will provide remote e-voting facility to all the Members to cast their votes on the resolutions set forth in the Notice. Additionally, the Company will also provide the facility of voting through e-voting system during the AGM. The detailed procedure for casting votes through remote e-voting/ e-voting at the AGM, including the manner in which Members holding shares in physical form or who have not registered their email addresses can cast their vote through remote e-voting/ e-voting at the AGM, shall be provided in the Notice.

Additional information:

- SEBI, vide its Master Circular dated February 6, 2026, has prescribed common and simplified norms for processing investor service requests by RTA and norms for furnishing PAN, KYC (contact details, bank details and specimen signature) and nomination details. As per the said circular, it is mandatory for the Members holding shares in physical form to, inter alia, furnish PAN, KYC details etc. Members holding shares in physical mode who have not registered the details, would be eligible for lodging grievance or service request only after registering such details. Further, any payments including dividend in respect of all physical folio in which PAN and KYC details (including contact details, bank details and specimen signature, etc.) are not updated, shall only be made electronically upon registering the required details. In this regard and to receive the dividend through electronic mode, all such Members are hereby requested to immediately submit the pending details in duly executed Form ISR-1 to KFin through post or in-person verification mode at KFin's address (i.e. KFin Technologies Limited, Selenium Tower B, Plot 31 and 32, Gachibowli, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Hyderabad – 500032) or by sending e-signed Form ISR-1 on einward.ris@kfintech.com through registered email ID. Members holding shares in dematerialised form are requested to register/ update the details with their respective DPs.
- Pursuant to the SEBI Circular dated January 30, 2026, Members are hereby informed that another 'Special Window' has been opened from February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027 to facilitate re-lodgement of physical share transfer requests that were originally lodged before April 1, 2019 but were rejected or returned due to deficiencies. This opportunity allows such requests to be re-submitted with the requisite documents by following the due process and upon verification, shares shall be transferred only in dematerialised form. Concerned Members are encouraged to utilize this special window provided by SEBI.

This advertisement is being issued for the information and benefit of all the Members of the Company in compliance with the applicable circulars.

For **Indus Towers Limited**
Sd/-
Samridhi Rodhe
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place: Gurugram
Date: July 25, 2026

US, Iran hold off on strikes after two weeks of escalation

Iran signalled it was refraining from any retaliatory attacks and held talks with Oman over the Strait of Hormuz

Oil's brief foray over $100 it last exceeded two months ago is just one of the potential inflation risks confronting policymakers. AFP

Oil near $100 puts Fed, central banks in rates spotlight

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

From Washington to London to Tokyo, central bankers are set to reveal just how worried they are about a return of oil to about $100 a barrel.

Three days of Group of Seven rate decisions, starting with the Federal Reserve on Wednesday, followed by peers at the Bank of England and Bank of Japan, may show varying degrees of vigilance at the prospect of more energy-driven inflation, even if none is predicted to act on that for now.

Together with the European Central Bank's signal of its readiness to hike interest rates again, investor bets point to possible moves as soon as September within much of that club, even if economists are less sure. Crude oil's brief foray above the $100 level it last exceeded two months ago is just one of the potential inflation risks confronting policymakers.

Aside from gains in other energy categories such as gas, investors are honing in on the implications of massive investment in artificial intelligence, as well as US President Donald Trump's bid to rebuild a wall of tariffs after setbacks at the Supreme Court.

Global bond markets point to some alarm among investors, with yields having jumped across the G7. On Friday, the US 30-year yield was just below its highest since 2007.

Other ripples from the renewed cost-of-living hit may be seen in central bank decisions around the world, with more than a dozen scheduled for the coming week.

Elsewhere, euro-zone growth and inflation numbers, Tokyo consumer prices, and South Korean exports will be among the highlights.

The Fed's 29 July rate decision is approaching with more suspense than many anticipated after June consumer price data in the US came in much cooler than expected. That's been overtaken, however, by renewed hostilities in West Asia.

The resulting surge in oil prices has boosted expectations for dissent from some officials—possibly Dallas Fed president Lorie Logan and Cleveland's Beth Hammack—who favour a rate increase now. It's also sparked widespread discussion over whether new chairman Kevin Warsh might surprise investors with a hike. On Thursday, a day after the decision, investors and policymakers will get an updated look at the state of economic activity, the Fed's preferred inflation gauge, and consumer spending.

Government data is projected to show gross domestic product rose at an annualized 2.1% pace in the second quarter, fuelled by consumers and business investment. A separate report is forecast to show a key inflation measure slowed in June amid lower gasoline prices that have since turned higher. It's another busy week also for the Asia-Pacific region, with several important monetary policy decisions and trade releases. First up is a rate decision from Singapore's central bank, a chance to dust of your protractors so you can check the slope of the currency band which is their policy tool. Pakistan's central bank will also announce its policy rate.

Ripples from the renewed cost-of-living hit may be seen in central bank decisions around the world

Friday morning brings a data dump from Japan, with industrial output, retail sales and jobless data for June as well as inflation in Tokyo for July.

The latter figure is a leading indicator for the nation and should give some guidance about what the Bank of Japan will decide later the same day. Taiwan will also announce second-quarter GDP on Friday.

Earlier in the week Australia reports June consumer inflation, and on Thursday Reserve Bank of Australia Deputy Governor Sarah Hunter is scheduled to speak. That comes after June data showed the labor market still going strong, upping expectations for more rate hikes.

It's a big week for trade data, with South Korea releasing its July trade stats on Saturday. Before that comes June figures for Hong Kong, the Philippines, and Thailand. Asian countries have been reporting record export numbers almost every month due to the soaring AI trade, and July looks like it will be more of the same.

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

The US paused an almost two-week run of strikes against Iran for a second night while the Islamic Republic signalled it was refraining from any retaliatory attacks and held talks with Oman over the Strait of Hormuz.

After striking Iran for 13 days, the US has apparently held off since late Friday without any explanation or announcement, raising questions over President Donald Trump's next move. Iran's army on Sunday said Tehran had halted its responses as a consequence.

"The US may have devised other scenarios for the coming days, but the current situation is not what they desire," spokesman Mohammad Akraminia told state TV. "If the Americans insist on continuing the war and airstrikes, the geography of the war will expand," he added.

The lull came as a weekend meeting between Iranian and Omani officials indicated a fresh attempt to resolve the crucial issue of shipping around Hormuz, a global chokepoint that's been at the heart of the conflict the US and Israel began in late February.

With traffic in that crucial waterway essentially paralyzed, skirmishes between Yemen's Houthi militants and Saudi Arabia have also ratcheted up tensions linked to another one—the Bab el-Mandeb in the southern Red Sea.

The Iran-backed Houthis said they fired missiles and drones at facilities linked to oil giant Saudi Aramco in the port towns of Jizan and Yanbu on Saturday. There was no immediate confirmation from the Saudi government or Aramco.

Saudi authorities briefly issued emergency warnings, before saying the danger had passed. A Saudi-led coalition responded by striking Houthi military positions later Saturday, according to *Yemen TV*, a channel affiliated with the country's internationally recognized government.

After striking Iran for 13 days, the US has apparently held off since late Friday without explanation or announcement. AFP

The escalation in the Red Sea compounds an already severe squeeze on regional energy flows caused by the near-total stoppage of traffic via Hormuz, previously the conduit for a fifth of global crude supplies.

The Houthis said they fired missiles and drones at facilities linked to oil giant Saudi Aramco on Saturday

On Friday, the Saudi-led coalition struck the port from which the Houthis' maritime assaults in the Red Sea typically originate. The Houthis also announced they would blockade Saudi ports and attacked three Saudi-linked oil tankers in the sea.

Any sustained disruption to Saudi Arabia's Red Sea export routes, through which it's sending millions of barrels of oil a day as a workaround, mainly from Yanbu, would likely push up crude prices even more.

Brent crude has soared around 27% in the past two weeks as US-Iran clashes worsened and the Houthis effectively opened a second front in the war. The global benchmark closed on Friday at $96.78 a barrel.

Trump, who's increasingly frustrated with Iran for refusing to reopen Hormuz, said late Friday the US is "locked and loaded" for major strikes on Iran. He added he had not made a decision on whether to go ahead, after telling Axios a few days ago he was mulling a "massive attack".

The New York Times reported that Trump and his advisers have decided to hold off plans to escalate the US strikes for now, in part over concerns that the war could drain the already-diminished stores of Patriot anti-missile interceptors and other air defence weapons in the region.

Trump has consistently said "he prefers a diplomatic solution, but he continues to retain all options if Iran continues terrorist activities in the Strait of Hormuz or against allies," White House spokesman Steven Cheung said in a statement. It would be "wise for Iran to work toward a negotiated deal".

One ally described the president as being in revenge mode against Iran, while others said he's looking to exact a cost from Tehran for the war, which has driven up energy prices and put Republicans in a tough spot politically ahead of the November midterms.

Speaking at the White House Correspondents' Dinner on Friday night, Trump said Iran would "love to make a deal" but he doesn't think "it's time yet".

He also said the warring sides were talking, though his administration is offering few details.

The deputy foreign ministers of Iran and Oman met in Tehran on Friday and Saturday to discuss the management of maritime navigation in the Hormuz strait, the Islamic Republic's foreign ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei said on Telegram.

"The talks were constructive and some progress was made," Baghaei said, without giving details. He said technical and political consultations were ongoing and there had been no change in the status of traffic through the strait.

Egyptian foreign minister Badr Abdelatty told Bloomberg on Thursday there was "a specific proposal" concerning freedom of navigation in the Hormuz strait that was under discussion and could lead to de-escalation. Egypt was in touch with Oman regarding the initiative, which would be subject to further talks between Iran and Oman, he said, without elaborating.

The apparent new Houthi aggression in the Red Sea came despite a shaky truce between the Saudi kingdom and Yemen, which has been in a civil war for 12 years.

Iran is the main funder and sponsor of the Houthis, though the group is more autonomous than other proxies such as Hezbollah in Lebanon.

Over 250,000 people flee wildfires ravaging France and Spain

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

More than 250,000 people fled towns and villages in Spain and France as uncontrolled wildfires moved ever closer to Madrid and Bordeaux, metropolitan areas that are home to more than 8 million people combined.

Authorities on Saturday ordered the immediate evacuation of some western suburbs of Bordeaux, a city in south-western France famed for its wines. Bordeaux's airport remains operational.

Some 197,000 people were evacuated in the Gironde and surrounding areas, interior minister Laurent Nunez said at a press conference in Paris. On Saturday night, officials in Gironde ordered another 55,000 people to evacuate, according to *Agence France-Presse*. Almost 98,000 hectares (242,000 acres) have been scorched in the blazes, a record in France, he said.

Although increased humidity overnight meant the conflagration in Gironde was no longer convective, or generating its own winds, the effort to get it under control "will be long and very difficult," Nunez said.

Sophie Brocas, Gironde's administrative head, issued a warning to people reluctant to leave their homes. More than 32,000 hectares have been burnt and 140 houses destroyed in the territory, she said, adding that the fire "is an ogre who can run very fast".

A total of 1,500 military personnel will be deployed, starting Saturday evening, to "protect property and people," the defense ministry said in a statement. An Airbus A400M military transport plane has been deployed to help contain the fires. Evacuees have in many cases been taken to municipal sports centres as a precautionary measure, mostly to avoid exposure to stifling smoke.

France and Spain have been at the epicentre of Europe's wildfire season. AFP

Authorities will cut short the final stage of the Tour de France cycling race due to take place on Sunday to free up additional security forces to help with the fire emergency, Paris police and the tour organizers said in a joint statement on X.

"In a spirit of national solidarity with the affected territories and populations, it has been decided to adapt the route of the final stage connecting Thoiry to Paris," they said. cyclists will now race 89 kilometres (55 miles) instead of the 133km originally planned, they said.

In Spain, 30,000 people were evacuated across Ávila province and the region west of Madrid, after 63,000 were evacuated or told to stay indoors as of Friday night. Authorities expect two separate fires raging there to merge at some point.

The final stage of the Tour de France was to be cut short to free up additional security forces to help with the fires

The municipal government in Madrid closed off parts of the city's main parks, telling people to keep away from trees as strong winds were forecast. No casualties have been reported so far.

"Our priority, our thinking, our aim, is for your lives, to save your lives and protect inhabited areas," Spanish prime minister Pedro Sánchez said at a press conference in the village of Cenicientos, in the fire zone about 80km from the capital. Unpredictable winds mean "we're going to have a challenging few hours," he said.

Madrid's air-quality monitoring system recorded a sharp deterioration in the city's west on Saturday morning, with the smell of smoke hanging in the air near the Royal Palace in central Madrid.

Five planes and two helicopters from the European Union's disaster response fleet have joined the effort in France and four planes were set to arrive in Spain on Saturday, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen said in a post on X. The bloc's Copernicus Earth observation and monitoring program is providing emergency mapping to support the response in both countries, she said. France and Spain have been at the epicentre of Europe's wildfire season, which started earlier than normal and accelerated in recent weeks as successive heat waves baked vegetation, making it easier for flames to spread rapidly. Before the weekend, fires had burned more than 329,000 hectares across the continent, destroying crops and disrupting transport.

Fires that have ravaged the south-western corner of the Madrid region, burning more than 9,000 hectares in their path, remained active and uncontrolled on Saturday, officials said. After reaching their most intense point on Friday afternoon, what had been three separate fronts merged into a single blaze that continued to spread in what regional authorities described as "beyond control capacity". Fires in Spain have so far passed through a Nasa complex in Robledo de Chavela and a 12th century monastery in Pelayos de la Presa, next to where one of the fires originated.

DeepSeek said to tell backers of funding pause after viral posts

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

DeepSeek has told prospective investors in its second fund-raising round that it's suspending the deal for now, people familiar with the matter said, days after comments widely attributed to founder Liang Wenfeng about US-Chinese AI competition went viral.

The Chinese AI pioneer verbally informed some of its would-be backers that they wouldn't be signing investment agreements in the coming days, as they had expected, people familiar with the matter said.

DeepSeek might choose to resume the deal process at a later date, the people said, asking to remain anonymous to talk about private discussions. The suspension stemmed in part from Liang's frustration over online reports about his comments to investors during his first financing deal, which closed in June and raised $7 billion for the AI lab, the people said.

Bloomberg hasn't verified the authenticity of those posts, which concerned a transcript of a meeting Liang held with unidentified parties.

Chinese media including *Yicai* reported this week that the billionaire founder talked about a reliance on Nvidia Corp. chips for AI development and China's persistent lag in AI sophistication relative to the US.

Deepseek didn't immediately respond to an emailed request for comment about the transcript or the fund-raising.

Negotiations remain fluid and the company may still choose to proceed. It's unclear if DeepSeek has communicated its intentions to all prospective investors in the current deal.

The talks kicked off mere weeks after DeepSeek closed its record first financing round, when it secured big names including Tencent Holdings Ltd. and Contemporary Amperex Technology Co. Ltd.

DeepSeek was aiming to raise at least 10 billion yuan of additional funds in a follow-on deal, though the final amount could go higher depending on the number of investors that sign on. The startup had been targeting a pre-money valuation of at least 480 billion yuan, *Bloomberg News* previously reported.

That's an increase from the roughly $50 billion price tag DeepSeek drew in its first round.

DeepSeek verbally informed some of its would-be backers that they won't be signing investment pacts in the coming days. REUTERS

In addition, the company has begun preparations for an initial public offering and may file as soon as this year, setting the stage for what could be a landmark debut for the country's technology industry.

DeepSeek has drawn enormous interest from would-be investors because it's one of a clutch of companies that sit at the heart of China's effort to compete globally on AI. It developed a model last year that stunned the industry, demonstrating the ability to build a cutting-edge yet efficient platform with fewer computing resources. The breakthrough demonstrated that Chinese companies could compete with the best of Silicon Valley despite US export restrictions on advanced hardware.

DeepSeek was aiming to raise at least 10 billion yuan in a follow-on deal, though the final amount could go higher

The startup is now chasing more funds to support an ambitious expansion plan, including an increase in computing capacity.

AI labs around the world are striking deals to secure the data centre infrastructure they need to train and operate AI services.

Founded in 2023, DeepSeek is owned by hedge fund Zhejiang High-Flyer Asset Management.

Its earlier fundraising set a record for first-time financing by a Chinese tech startup. Apart from Tencent and CATL, it also notably drew the backing of the National Artificial Intelligence Industry Investment Fund, one of the vehicles that spearheads Beijing's over-arching endeavors in the sector.

DeepSeek's senior management has told potential investors that the startup will prioritize groundbreaking AI research over short-term commercialization, *Bloomberg News* has reported.

Liang pledged in at least one meeting with investors to keep developing open-source AI models while pursuing the broader goal of achieving artificial general intelligence, underscoring the company's focus on advancing the frontiers of AI rather than monetization.

Liang's net worth more than doubled after his firm's most recent fund-raising round, making the Chinese entrepreneur the world's richest among creators of AI models.

He's now worth $36 billion, up from about $16.7 billion previously, according to the Bloomberg Billionaires Index. That ranks him well above Anthropic PBC co-founder Dario Amodei and OpenAI's Greg Brockman.

NEWS IN NUMBERS

₹7,920 cr
THE CONSOLIDATED revenue from operations reported by IPO-bound fintech firm PhonePe in FY26, up 11.5% from the previous financial year.

₹171.84 cr
THE WORLDWIDE gross box office collection recorded by *Jana Nayagan*, starring C. Joseph Vijay, currently Tamil Nadu's CM, in three days since its release.

$100 mn
THE AMOUNT AI startup Prentis, backed by LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman and Zynga founder Mark Pincus, is in talks to raise at a $1 billion valuation.

$644 mn
THE DIVORCE settlement amount a Korean court ordered SK Group Chairman CheyTae-won to pay ex-wife Roh Soh-yeong, from the earlier $940 M order.

$200 bn
THE ESTIMATED value of the Samsung Electronics-Broadcom partnership for memory chips, contract manufacturing, and advanced packaging through 2030.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

India cautions on jobs in maritime zones


In an advisory, New Delhi flagged concerns over the security situation in the Black Sea. AP

India on Sunday urged its citizens to carefully assess the security situation before taking up jobs in maritime zones witnessing conflicts, especially in the Black Sea region. In an advisory, New Delhi flagged concerns over the security situation in and around the Black Sea and adjoining maritime areas, saying they "remains highly volatile" due to the ongoing conflict. The advisory came days after five Indians were killed in attacks on two commercial vessels in the Black Sea region in the last one week. "Indian nationals intending to undertake employment on commercial vessels operating in or transiting the conflict-affected region are advised to carefully assess the prevailing security risks before accepting such assignments," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said. It said the situation in and around the Black Sea and adjoining maritime areas "remains highly volatile due to the ongoing conflict." "Commercial vessels operating in or transiting these waters are facing significant security risks, including missile and drone attacks," it said. "Indian nationals requiring consular assistance are advised to contact the Embassy of India or Consulates in the region," the MEA said. PTI

PTI

Take govt norms as guardrails, not as tollgates: FM

Sitharaman's remarks are in line with the government's ongoing deregulation drive

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The government's regulatory philosophy is anchored in enabling growth while keeping risks in check, with rules acting as guardrails rather than tollgates so as not to hinder business activity, finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Sunday.

Sitharaman highlighted deregulation, infrastructure building and macroeconomic stability as key drivers of growth.

Speaking at the *NDTV Profit* Business Leadership Awards, she said that the government is pursuing a trust-based regulatory framework that facilitates enterprise while protecting public interest. "Our conviction is simple. Regulation should be a guardrail, not a tollgate. Deregulation is a habit we intend to keep," she said.

The finance minister said that the government has undertaken one of the country's most extensive deregulation exercises, with the Centre and states working together to simplify compliance requirements. As part of the exercise, the government has extended the validity of licences and certificates, replaced several physical inspections with third-party certification and decriminalised routine business lapses, Sitharaman said.

The finance minister's remarks are in line with the Centre's deregulation drive aimed at replacing approval-based compliance with a trust-based regulatory framework. Over the past two years, the government has decriminalised several business-related provisions, streamlined compliance requirements, expanded faceless and digital approvals, rationalized quality control orders (QCOs) and asked ministries to review and repeal outdated rules, while maintaining regulatory oversight through risk-based enforcement and quality standards.

She said that India's growth strategy rests on five pillars, which include a trust-based regulatory system, quality infrastructure, stronger global partnerships, macroeconomic stability and continued investment in future generations.

Highlighting the country's economic performance, she said India continues to be resilient despite an uncertain global environment.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

CCI says avoiding suo motu cases

Competition Commission of India (CCI) is avoiding taking up suo motu cases unless nobody is willing to come forward, as there is a conflict of interest in terms of establishing and also adjudicating such cases, the regulator informed a Parliamentary panel.

The watchdog has the mandate to curb unfair business practices, as well as foster fair competition, across sectors. The Committee on Subordinate Legislation of the Rajya Sabha that examined various regulations and guidelines of the CCI flagged the issue of decline in suo motu cases. During the committee's meeting on 19 May, CCI chairperson Ravneet Kaur told the panel members that suo motu cases were more frequent during the initial years due to limited public awareness regarding competition law.

The watchdog's submissions are part of the committee's report tabled in Parliament this week. PTI

Nepal seeks India nod on National ID

Nepal has requested India to recognise the National Identity Card (NID) as a valid travel document for Nepali citizens visiting the country, a move that will allow the NID to be used alongside the existing citizenship certificate and passport, a senior official said on Sunday.

The Department of Immigration has forwarded the proposal to the Indian government through diplomatic channels, seeking recognition of the NID for travel to India, spokesperson Tika Ram Dhakal said.

"We have already sent the proposal to the ministry of foreign affairs via the home ministry, and the foreign ministry has forwarded it to the concerned authorities of India," he said. PTI


ABDL owns brands such as Officer's Choice and ICONiQ. HT

ABDL targets mid-teen growth in FY27

Alco-beverage firm Allied Blenders and Distillers Ltd (ABDL) expects to deliver mid-teen growth in revenue and volume in fiscal year 2027 (FY27), driven by premiumisation, exports and capacity expansion, despite uncertainties arising from geopolitical tensions and supply chain disruptions, managing director Amar Sinha said. ABDL, which owns brands such as Officer's Choice and ICONiQ, is pursuing a three-year transformation strategy focused on premiumisation, strengthening margins and expanding its international footprint, he said.

The Chhabria family-promoted firm, which is expanding its international footprint, expects to increase presence to 60-70 countries over the next three years, driven by premium and mass-premium portfolio. "We would have a volume and top-line growth of mid-teens in FY27. EBITDA margins should remain stable and comparable to FY26," Sinha told PTI in an interaction. The company said its premiumisation drive remains the key growth lever going forward as it reported a 5.8% year-on-year rise in income from operations to ₹984 crore in the June quarter on volume of 9 million cases (9 litres each), up 6.2%. PTI

PNB profit to cross ₹20,000 crore mark

Enthused by the consistent financial performance of the last four quarters, Punjab National Bank managing director and chief executive officer Ashok Chandra exuded confidence that the bank's profit would surpass the ₹20,000 crore mark this financial year.

The public sector lender had earned a net profit of ₹16,904 crore in the previous financial year. From the second quarter of last financial year, the bank has been maintaining a net profit of over ₹5,000 crore every quarter, Chandra told *PTI* in an interview.

Besides, he said, retail, agri, MSME, and self-help groups are going to be the focus areas for asset creation. PTI

The company is strategically poised to take advantage of a shift taking place. REUTERS

Tata Technologies sees FY27 breakout

Global product engineering and digital services firm Tata Technologies Ltd is confident of having a 'breakout year' in the ongoing fiscal year riding on accelerated investment from automobile manufacturers on new products that have helped it win full development projects, according to its chief executive officer (CEO) and managing director Warren Harris. The company is strategically poised to take advantage of a shift taking place in the industry where OEMs are increasingly looking to outsource more development work while focussing only on the core of the DNA of their respective brands, Harris told *PTI* in an interview. "The industry from a product perspective is having the catch up from a period of under-investment and we are the beneficiaries of that because we won a number of full vehicle programmes in the first quarter (of this fiscal). That is helping us," he said. PTI

Hindustan Zinc plans ₹5k cr capex

Vedanta group firm Hindustan Zinc Ltd (HZL) is likely to spend about $500-600 million (around Rs 5,000 crore) in the current financial year, with most of the capital earmarked for projects already underway and a smaller portion reserved for new initiatives, its chief executive officer (CEO) Arun Misra said.

In an interview to *PTI*, Misra said roughly 80% of the guidance is intended for projects that are currently running, while about 20% will be allocated to new projects that the firm plans to announce soon. He added that the group's total project capacity is about 1 million tonnes, of which 250,000 tonnes (25%) has already been approved with a capex of ₹12,000 crore covering mining and mineralisation.

Orders for mining have been placed and construction of the smelter has started, but milling and concentrate-related orders are yet to be finalised, the CEO said. PTI

'Niva Bupa has consciously focused on women athletes'

Soumya Gupta
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MUMBAI

The 23rd Commonwealth Games kicked off in Glasgow this month, with India fielding more than 120 athletes including weightlifting champion Mirabai Chanu and Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra. Health insurance firm Niva Bupa is among the official sponsors of this edition of the Games. Nimish Agarwal, head–digital business unit, and chief marketing officer (CMO), tells how female sports stars can help earn trust in a tricky category. Edited excerpts from an interview:

INTERVIEW

Why did you sponsor the Commonwealth Games?

We have a global sponsorship with Bupa and the Commonwealth Games. As Niva Bupa, we haven't done a lot of sporting properties, but this global partnership has been in the making for a long time.

The first question to ask ourselves is: what stories does the brand want to tell? The story of a comeback from an athlete's standpoint has not been told enough. People talk of medals, honours and the path to success. Cricketers get spotted very well and there is a reasonable amount of money in that sport. But this is not true for the Commonwealth Games. Athletes come from very different backgrounds and they are talked about a lot when they are first spotted, but not over a long period of time.

We chose the stories of Saina and Mirabai because both have gone through a health setback and made a comeback. But the journey of that setback to comeback hasn't been talked about. This journey is what we cover as a health insurance company. [Our pitch is that] a lot of people can't make [their own] comeback because most don't have health insurance.

Your campaign centres around women stars. Do you think women are finally commanding the same pull as male sports stars in India?

It is still early and there is a lot of ground to be covered, unfortunately. We have the women's IPL happening and the good thing is that the conversation [around women's sports] has started. Advertisers want to put more money in women's sports.

But this is my personal view. As a brand, we don't do gender as a pivot; we focus on the story to be told. We want to be remembered as a brand that is authentic and is telling a story that needs to be told, not as the 50th brand sponsoring cricket. Youngsters are choosing brands that are authentic, and we want to be a brand for the long term. Since transitioning from Max Bupa to Niva Bupa over the past five years, we have consciously focused on giving women more than their fair share of representation.

> We chose the stories of Saina and Mirabai because both have gone through a health setback
>
> **Nimish Agarwal**
> Head–digital business unit and CMO, Niva Bupa

For an extended version of this story go to, livemint.com.

Exporters face higher storage bills with port congestion hitting firms

Rituraj Baruah & Manas Pimpalkhare
NEW DELHI


Congestion raises container unloading time from the typical 48 hours to 72 hours. BLOOMBERG

The Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO) has approached the Centre to help mitigate disruptions caused by the West Asia war, including port congestion and surcharges imposed by shipping lines, showed a 22 July letter accessed by *Mint*.

The request comes as ports, particularly in western India, are facing congestion, driving up costs for exporters. Shipping freight rates are expected to rise by as much as 50%, particularly on routes connecting India and West Asia.

The Drewry World Container Index (WCI), the benchmark for container rates, as on 23 July, was at $4,374 per 40-foot container, 3.8% lower than $4,547 on 16 July. The index is updated every week. However, it is still 130% higher than $1,899 on 26 February, prior to the start of the war.

With Iran-aligned Houthis enforcing a maritime blockade in the Red Sea and disrupting shipping lanes, more vessels are calling at Indian ports, leading to congestion and delays, said Unmesh Sharad Wagh, commissioner of customs and board member of Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA).

"There are not many options for them. One is Karachi port, and the other is Indian ports; they prefer to dock at Indian ports until the situation normalizes," he said.

Indian ports are functioning as transshipment hubs for these vessels, he added. For example, a ship that sailed from Jebel Ali in the UAE to Indonesia is docked here on its way back to West Asia.

Congestion raises container unloading time from the typical 48 hours to 72 hours and may push inventory levels to about 1.5 times the normal. "However, the situation is not unmanageable as of now and is being efficiently dealt with," he added.

"While some Western ports may face congestion, the situation is largely normal at eastern ports," said an official at Kakinada Seaports Ltd.

State-run JNPA and Adani Group-owned Mundra Port in western India together account for nearly two-thirds of the country's containerized maritime trade.

However, Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd, denied reports of congestion, saying operations across its ports, including Mundra Port, continue to run normally and at optimal efficiency.

"We continue to work closely with our customers and stakeholders to ensure seamless operations and minimize any potential impact on trade arising from the evolving situation in West Asia," an Adani Group spokesperson said.

India has 12 major ports and more than 200 non-major (state) ports. Together, they handle over 16 million TEUs (twenty-foot equivalent units) of container traffic annually and facilitate about $1.6 trillion in maritime trade, per the Directorate General of Shipping.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

India among IBM's top five markets

India has emerged as one of the top five growth markets globally for open-source solutions provider Red Hat and its parent company IBM, driven by the country's deep-rooted embrace of open-source architecture and a burgeoning talent pool, a top company executive said. India is currently at the centre of the company's global strategy, both as a critical market and a hub for engineering excellence, Navtej Singh Bal, vice president and general manager, India and South Asia, Red Hat, noted.

"India, what started as a business from scratch, has actually scaled up nicely to be one of our fastest-growing businesses globally, and this is primarily because India has actually embraced open-source software at its core.

"I would say India would be, both for Red Hat and IBM, one of the top five growth markets globally," Bal said. Red Hat, the enterprise open-source solutions company that IBM bought in 2019 for about $35 billion, has offices in Delhi, Mumbai, Pune, and Bengaluru. PTI

INSIDE THE GEN Z PROTEST THAT REDEFINED INDIA

How exam leaks exposed a generation's deeper anger over jobs and education

(Clockwise from above) A student holds the popular placard 'hate the system, not the country' in response to allegations of 'anti-India' activities; Protesters hold banners vowing to speak up and raise slogans at Jantar Mantar protest last week; Protesters wave the viral 'Hum Jeet Gaye' meme from Lagaan after Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as the Union education minister; A group of students makes posters seeking accountability for the Neet paper leaks; Students raise freedom fighter Bhagat Singh's picture and wave the national flag as more people join the protest in solidarity.

RUPANJAL CHAUHAN AND PAYAL BHATTACHARYA

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Payal Bhattacharya, Rupanjal Chauhan & Pragya Srivastava

NEW DELHI

"We did it!" shouted 25-year-old Simpi Yadav, beaming, as news broke Saturday afternoon of Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as India's education minister. Just four days earlier, she had quietly boarded a train from Nagpur to Delhi and headed straight to Jantar Mantar, the beating heart of the student uprising this year.

Yadav joined students from across the country who had begun gathering in Delhi in late June to demand Pradhan's resignation over this year's undergraduate medical entrance exam papers being leaked, which had forced millions of students to re-take the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET). While that was the trigger, the broader issue raised by the protesters, including Yadav, centred around education reforms. The protest was called off on 25 July after Pradhan put in his papers.

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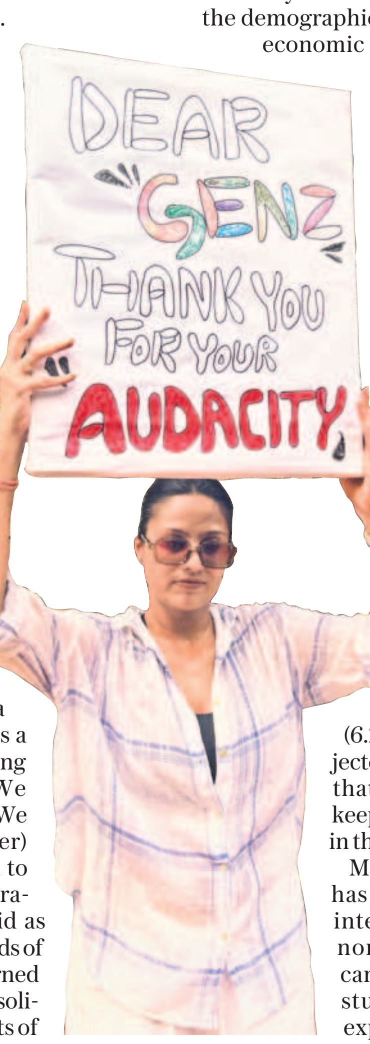
During the day, Yadav painted posters, raised slogans, and ate the free food sent by people in solidarity. At night, she found shelter in a nearby Gurdwara. Driven to demand accountability from a government she felt had failed her, Yadav's story was one of systemic neglect: constrained by her family's strained financial background, private education was never an option.



The domino effect landed her in a basic B.Sc programme instead of her dream course, engineering. This led to negligible job prospects, with internships capped at a mere ₹3,000–4,000 a month. She now earns a modest living by tutoring school students. "We have been left behind. We want (Prime Minister) Modi ji to take action to secure the next generation's future," she said as she sat among thousands of protesters who had turned up at Jantar Mantar in solidarity following reports of police brutality on 20 July during the march to Parliament.

Yadav's story is that of millions of young Indians who play an important role in India's global standing but have been left behind in what economists have described for more than a decade as a jobless growth story.

DIVIDEND DELAYED

For years, India has enjoyed the tag of the world's fastest growing major economy, with gross domestic product (GDP) averaging 6–7% over the previous decade. Yet, this growth story has not yet achieved widespread prosperity.

Among emerging market peers, India has recorded the second-fastest pace of growth, but also the highest youth unemployment rate, at 16%. China, too, has a high unemployment rate among its youth, but the world's second-largest economy is at the end of its demographic window and had delivered a rapid rise in per capita GDP during its peak.

A nuanced look at India's growth story reveals that a strike rate of 6–7% is not enough. Take, for example, Japan and Germany. Both these countries entered the demographic dividend phase—the economic growth potential that results from a higher share of the working-age population as compared to the dependent population—and delivered nearly 10% compound average growth rate in per capita GDP between 1950 and 2000.

Among the countries that joined the list later and still have an ongoing demographic dividend phase, India's strike rate of around 4.8% pales when compared with China (10.8%), Vietnam (10.2%), and South Korea (6.2%). India's growth trajectory currently is close to that of Brazil and risks keeping the country stuck in the middle-income trap.

More importantly, India has already induced an intergenerational economic anxiety, which came to fore during the student protests that expanded in blitzkrieg fashion all over the country in a matter of days, and caught the Union government by surprise.

Lekha Chakraborty, a professor at the National Institute of Public Finance and Policy (NIPFP), says various economic theories can explain this mass movement in India. The 'relative deprivation' theory of rising aspirations colliding with stagnant outcomes, the 'youth bulge' theory of large educated but under-employed people that leads to political movements, and the Mancur Olson-style collective-action dynamics solved by social media, where the old friction of organizing and the high costs attached to protests no longer exist.

Multiple protesters *Mint* spoke with said they learnt about the protest through Instagram and reels on other social media platforms.

NOTHING TO LOSE

About 200 metres from Yadav sat 22-year-old Aniket Chaudhary from Ghaziabad. He declared that despite coming from a family that supports the current government, he was at the protest as he felt his future was already doomed.

"After my BCA (Bachelor of Computer Applications), I could only get jobs paying around ₹10,000, which prompted me to try for government exams," said Chaudhary, who is preparing for the Staff Selection Commission (SSC) exam, adding that paper delays and leaks had pushed many like him to the brink. A few other young men had similar stories to share. Data lays bare their struggles.

The expenditure by the Union education ministry has nearly halved as a percentage of India's GDP in the last 15 years. In other words, while India's economy kept growing, the investment on public education failed to keep pace.

India has made great strides in achieving 100% gross enrolment ratio at the primary education level and at least 80% at the secondary level, but the latest data points to significant deterioration, with school admissions declining by 8.6 million between 2023-24 and 2025-26.

The cuts in public funding and lack of quality education push many towards private education, and leaves behind those coming from weak economic and social backgrounds. A survey by the statistics ministry last year showed a stark gap between fee structures in government and private un-aided schools. On average, the fees at private schools can cost more than 10 times what one would pay at a government school.

At the same time, the return on investment remains slim. Professional courses like MBA and engineering offer high chances of employment. But a regular bachelor's degree offers only a 55–60% employability rate.

What this transpires into is a high level of unemployment among the educated,

TURN TO PAGE 11

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KEY NUMBERS

16%

India's youth unemployment rate, which happens to be the highest among the major emerging economies

8.6 MILLION

The number of students lost from India's school system in just two academic years (2023-24 and 2025-26)

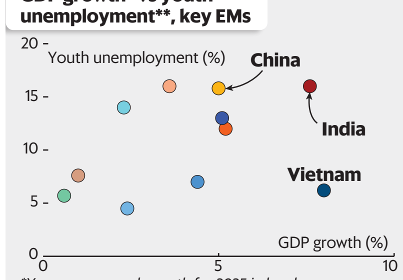
76.4%

The percentage of post-millennials who say finding a job is difficult, according to the YouGov-*Mint*-CPR survey

Catalyst for change

Intergenerational economic anxiety from jobless growth was at the heart of the protest

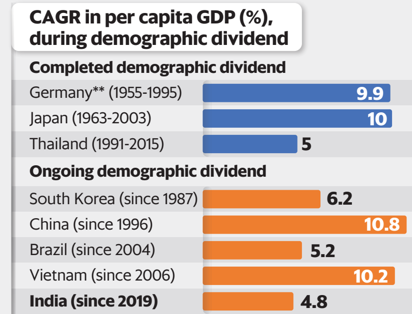
GDP growth* vs youth unemployment**, key EMs



*Year-on-year real growth for 2025 in local currency. **Refers to % of the labor force aged 15 to 24 that is without work, available for work, and actively seeking a job, based on International Labour Organization estimates for 2025.

Source: World Bank

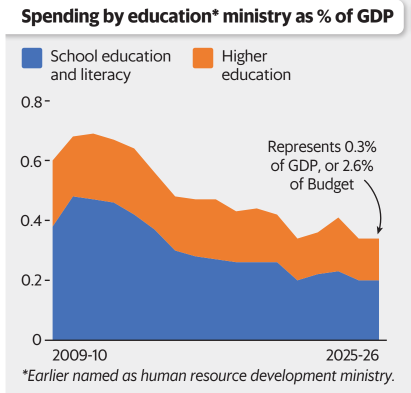
CAGR in per capita GDP (%), during demographic dividend



CAGR: Compound annual growth rate. *In the case of the ongoing period, 2025 data has been taken as the final figure. **CAGR has been calculated from 1960, as standard data is available only since then.

Source: World Bank, Mint calculations

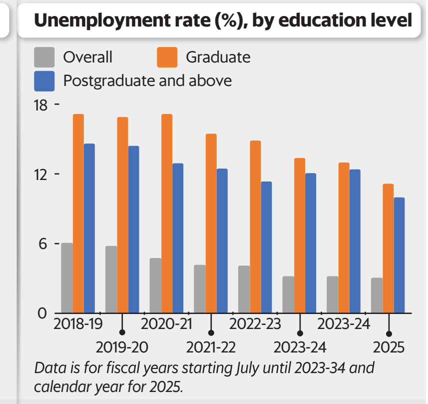
Spending by education* ministry as % of GDP



*Earlier named as human resource development ministry.

Source: CMIE

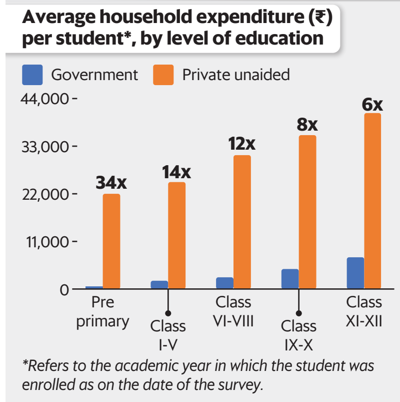
Unemployment rate (%), by education level



Data is for fiscal years starting July until 2023-34 and calendar year for 2025.

Source: Periodic Labour Force Survey

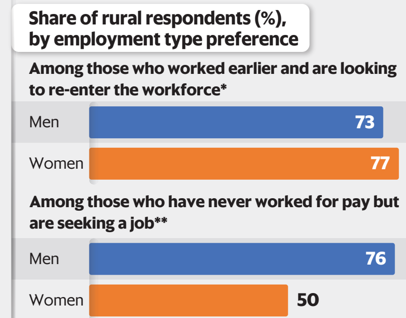
Average household expenditure (₹) per student*, by level of education



*Refers to the academic year in which the student was enrolled as on the date of the survey.

Source: Comprehensive Modular Survey: Education, Apr-Jun 2025 by statistics ministry

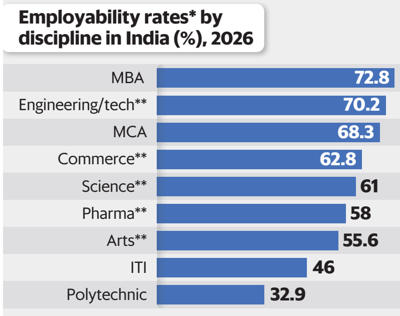
Share of rural respondents (%), by employment type preference



The survey had 5,169 respondents aged 18-35 in rural India (unemployed, underemployed, out of school/education/skilling). Sub-sample: *218 men, 565 women, **373 men, 1,083 women.

Source: "State of Rural Youth Employment" report 2024, DIU, GDI, and TRI

Employability rates* by discipline in India (%), 2026

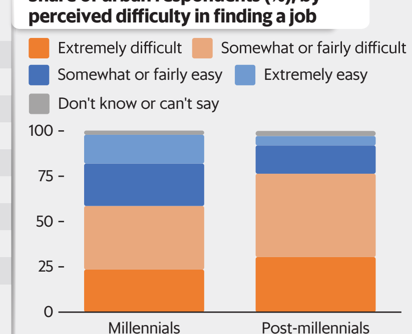


*Based on outcomes from over 100,000 candidates taking the Global Employability Test (GET) and hiring intent data from over 1,000 organizations. **Represents bachelor's degrees. MBA: Master of business administration. MCA: Master of computer applications. ITI: Industrial training institutes.

Source: India Skills Report 2026, ETS

Chart: Puneet Kumar Arora, Jaydeep Mukherjee

Share of urban respondents (%), by perceived difficulty in finding a job



Survey based on responses from 10,022 individuals across 207 towns and cities, including 3,392 millennials (born 1982-1996) and 4,264 post-millennials (born 1997 onwards).

Source: YouGov-Mint-CPR Millennial Survey, Mar-Apr 2026

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How do active momentum funds work, and are they worth buying?

Momentum investing involves buying stocks that have been rising and selling those that are losing steam

Jash Kriplani
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Active momentum funds have outpaced the broader market over the past three months and six months, which was a period of heightened volatility.

In the three months to 23 July 2026, active momentum funds returned an average of about 6.4%, against 1.2% for the Nifty 500 total return index (TRI) and negative 0.7% for the Nifty 50 TRI. (See gfx)

Over a six-month period, the funds returned close to 10.8% on average, against 1.8% for the Nifty 500 TRI and negative 4.1% for the Nifty 50 TRI. However, the returns of active momentum funds varied widely: from 3.7% to 15.2%. That spread in returns reflects the different models these funds run to play the momentum factor.

Here's a look at how different active momentum funds work and whether you should consider these for your portfolio.

How do they work?

Momentum investing involves buying stocks that have been rising and selling those that are losing steam. Passive momentum funds do this mechanically by tracking an index such as the Nifty500 Momentum 50 or the Nifty200 Momentum 30, which ranks stocks on their six-month and one-year price returns and rebalances twice a year. Active momentum funds run their own models, which differ sharply in the signals they follow.

There are earnings-momentum funds, which anchor to fundamentals rather than price. Examples include ICICI Prudential AMC and Kotak AMC's active momentum funds. "Our strategy is based on earnings momentum, not price momentum. We look for companies where the earnings trajectory is improving and earnings are coming in better than market expectations," said Manasvi Shah, fund manager at ICICI Prudential AMC. To avoid placing undue weight on a single strong quarter, the fund assesses earnings trends over the previous three quarters and complements this with a qualitative review of company-specific developments, news flow and management actions.

Some funds blend price momentum with a fundamental or quality overlay. Motilal Oswal applies its momentum model on top of stocks already under its research coverage, vetted through the firm's quality, growth, longevity and price (QGLP) framework. "We apply our proprietary momentum model, which generates investment ideas and suggested allocations. The quality filter remains intact because every stock is already under active coverage," said Ajay Khandelwal, head of equity at Motilal Oswal AMC. "If a stock has shown no meaningful price movement over the last three to six months, it generally will not feature in this scheme," he added.

Nippon India's active momentum fund also blends price and earnings momentum, but is built in a way that lets it adjust to the market's mood. Its model can tilt the portfolio towards more aggressive, higher-risk stocks when the market is recovering, and towards steadier, lower-volatility names when the market looks overheated or is falling. It uses signals such as how broad the rally is to decide when to switch.

> Since active momentum funds are still new, they should ideally be given time to build longer track records

At the other end are the price-momentum funds—such as Samco, Union and the newly launched NJ Momentum Fund—which follow price signals through their internal rules and filters. Even within this group, approaches vary: some models leave room for the fund manager to act between scheduled rebalances, while NJ's model is fully rule-based with no manager discretion. Union Mutual Fund, for instance, allows its manager to exit a stock before scheduled re-balances if an adverse event threatens value.

What all of them promise over a passive momentum fund is faster rebalancing and a wider hunting ground. "Faster rebalancing is one of the biggest advantages of an active momentum strategy," said Umeshkumar Mehta, chief investment officer at Samco AMC, whose universe spans around 750 stocks. Union AMC makes a similar case. "This fund is rebalanced more frequently, which keeps the momentum factor fresh," said Gaurav Chopra, fund manager–equity at Union AMC, whose model screens the top 1,000 companies by free-float market capitalization.

Managing the downside

Momentum's weak spot is that it can fall hard when trends reverse. Active momentum funds try to manage this in different ways.

Samco relies on hedging. "If markets decline, we hedge the portfolio through futures of underlying shares or by exiting stocks where futures are not available, to reduce net equity exposure," said Mehta. He cited a live example: in almost all of March 2026, during the peak of the US-Iran war tension, the fund was hedged by 50%. So, half of its portfolio had zero net equity exposure. In the early days of April the fund went back to 100% equity exposure. The strategy can, in principle, cut net equity exposure sharply in a prolonged bear market.

ICICI Prudential's fund leans on its earnings signal and a tilt toward larger companies when conditions turn. "The strategy is market-cap agnostic, drawing its investment universe from the Nifty 500 Index. While it can invest across large-, mid- and small-cap stocks, allocations are driven by earnings momentum rather than market capitalization. As a result, the portfolio may tilt towards large-caps when they offer stronger earnings visibility," said Shah. She noted that the strategy is likely to be less effective during prolonged sideways markets, where the absence of a clear earnings momentum trend limits the opportunity to generate differentiated returns.

Union's active momentum fund raises cash in what it calls 'anti-momentum' phases. "During periods of anti-momentum, we try to raise cash levels to permissible limits under the investment mandate to protect the downside," said Chopra, adding that the fund does this when its model throws up relatively few stocks that clear its momentum tests. Liquidity, he said, is a critical input in the model, which is built to hold only companies that are widely owned and traded, helping keep impact costs low during rebalancing.

"We monitor the portfolio on a daily basis. If price momentum weakens, we can reduce or exit positions without waiting for the next earnings update," said Khandelwal of Motilal Oswal AMC.

Investor takeaways

Financial advisors say investors should first understand the risks of momentum factor. "Momentum as a factor has done well in Indian markets over the long term. A momentum strategy paired with certain qualitative filters can also build some quality checks into the portfolio, which is what active momentum funds seek to do," said Kavitha Menon, founder of Probitus Wealth. She cautioned, however, that momentum can still see sharper corrections when markets fall, unless the fund's model has strong controls to manage the downside.

Because active momentum funds are still new, they should ideally be given time to build longer track records. Investors should watch how these funds participate in both the upside and the downside of markets before considering them.

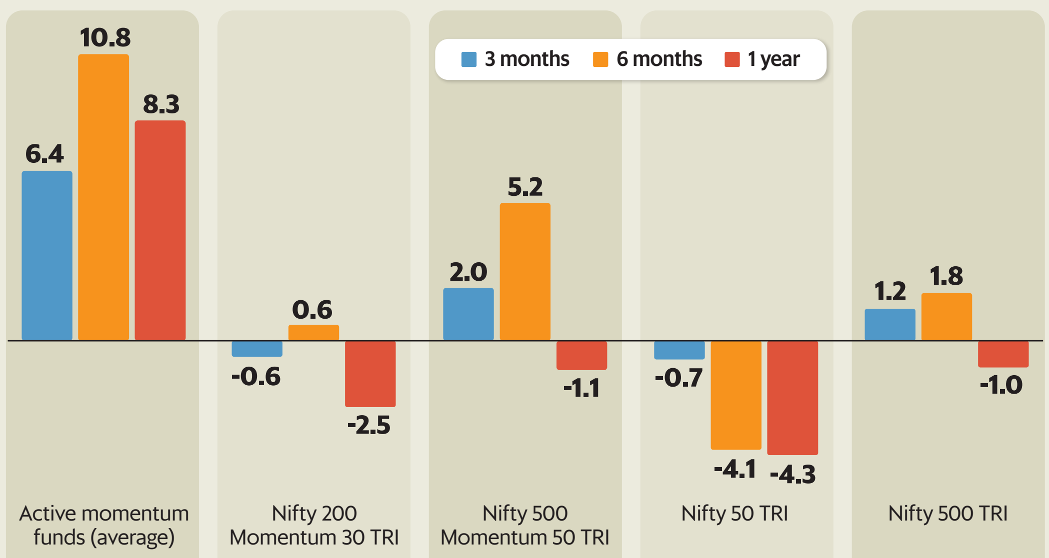
Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.

The active momentum bet

Active momentum funds run their own models, which differ sharply in the signals they follow.

Recent performance of active momentum funds

Average returns of active momentum funds vs market and momentum indices (in %)



Data as of 23 July 2026; TRI stands for total return index. Source: Ace MF

Types of active momentum funds

- **Earnings-driven:** pick stocks on improving earnings, not price.
- **Earnings+price momentum:** blend both through internal models.
- **Price-momentum only:** follow price signals via rule-based internal models.

Takeaways

- **Let these** funds build a track record as active momentum funds are still new.
- **Track funds'** performance versus traditional index-linked momentum funds over long-term.
- **Watch if** the funds' internal models help curb downside risks of the momentum factor.

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POWER POINT

DHIRENDRA KUMAR

We welcome your views and comments at mintmoney@livemint.com

WHY GOAL-BASED INVESTING BEATS ONE BIG PORTFOLIO

There is an old household habit that many of you will recognise from your own childhoods, of the woman who divided the month's money into small cloth pouches the moment her husband's pay arrived: one for vegetables, one for milk, one for the household help, and larger ones set aside for savings and for a daughter's wedding.

Anyone with a modern financial education looks at this and sees something uneducated, because the first thing such an education teaches you is that money is fungible, that a rupee is a rupee regardless of which pouch it sits in, and that keeping the wedding rupee apart from the vegetable rupee when both could be in one sensibly managed pool is the sort of thing beginners do before they learn better.

The objection is worth discussing seriously. If you have money spread across a dozen little bags, some of it is bound to be sitting idle when it could be working harder somewhere else, and the whole thing looks like a failure to optimise.

A financial advisor would tell you to pool everything, look at the total, decide on a sensible allocation for the lot, and stop pretending that money wearing one label behaves any differently from money wearing another.

On paper this is unarguable, and it is the reason the pouch system gets dismissed as the charming inefficiency of a generation that did not know better.

Goal-based investing

What the sophisticated view misses is that the inefficiency was doing important work. The reason money should not be fungible in your hands is that fungibility is what allows you to rob one goal to feed another, and to do it while telling yourself some reasonable story about why it makes sense.

> If you have money spread across a dozen little bags, some of it is bound to be sitting idle

When everything sits in one pool, it becomes very easy to borrow from the retirement money for a stock you feel strongly about, to dip into the emergency fund for something that is not an emergency, or to run the entire portfolio at a single level of risk because the average across your goals looks acceptable even though no individual goal is being served properly.

The drawstring on that pouch was not there to earn a better return. It was there as a small piece of friction between the household and its own worst impulses. That friction is a feature.

This is where experienced investors trip over the very thing they believe they have outgrown. Having read enough and traded enough to feel that the basics are beneath them, they collapse their savings into one large, cleverly managed heap and lose the match between a particular sum of money and the particular purpose it was meant to serve.

They are too busy with asset allocation models and tactical tilts to notice that they no longer know which part of their wealth is standing behind their child's education and which part they are free to take risks with, and the answer, in practice, is that all of it is available for risk-taking.

The separation into goals is not really about the money at all, which is why the advisor's arithmetic argument against it misses the point.

It is about protecting each goal from the others and, more than that, to protect all of them from you, so that when the tempting idea arrives, as it always does, something reminds you that this money already has a different job to do.

The system may look inefficient because it refuses to let capital flow to wherever it might do best, but that refusal is the point.

The efficiency that sophisticated investors like solves a problem the beginner does not have, and the inefficiency they mock actually creates a problem.

Dhirendra Kumar is founder and chief executive officer of Value Research, an independent investment advisory firm.

How different assets are taxed?

This table shows the post Budget 2024 capital gains tax treatment across different assets. As a uniform rule, LTCG on all assets except debt funds is now 12.5%, and STCG on assets where STT is paid is 20%, while assets without STT continue to be taxed at slab rates.

	Holding period for LTCG	STCG tax rate	LTCG tax rate
Equity MFs, ETFs and stocks	>12 months	**20%**	**12.5%***
Gold ETFs	>12 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Reits/InVITs	>12 months	**20%**	**12.5%**
Listed bonds	>12 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Debt MFs**			
Bought before 1 April 2023	>24 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Bought 1 April 2023 onwards	NA	Slab rate	Slab rate
Gold MFs^, physical gold, overseas MFs, FOFs	>24 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Foreign equity, international ETFs	>24 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Real estate	>24 months	Slab rate	Bought after 23 July 2024: 12.5% Bought before 23 July 2024: lower of 12.5% without indexation and 20% with indexation

*On gains above ₹1.25 lakh. **includes funds that have invested over 65% of proceeds in debt and money market instruments.
MF: Mutual funds; ETFs: Exchange-traded funds; Reits: Real Estate Investment Trusts; InVITs: Infrastructure Investment Trusts; FOF: Fund of Funds; NA: Not Applicable. All rates are base; surcharge and cess extra. ^gold MFs that invest in an underlying gold ETF. Those without an FoF structure qualify as long-term asset after 1 year. Source: *Mint* Research

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The Gen Z protest that redefined India

FROM PAGE 10

with graduates facing a high joblessness rate of 11.2% and post-graduates, 10%. While the data shows these numbers have dropped over the years, the latest State of Working India report by Ajim Premji University noted that the rise in employment levels in the post-pandemic years came from more agricultural and self-employment jobs, particularly for women, rather than high-quality ones.

Contrast this with the aspirations of young people in rural areas, who overwhelmingly (nearly three-fourths) desire salaried jobs, a 2024 survey by the Development Intelligence Unit (DIU) et al revealed. But salaried jobs are limited. Only about 13% jobs are classified as regular wage or salaried jobs in rural areas and 47% in urban areas. Job anxiety is quite prevalent in urban areas as well, with more post-millenials (76.4%) than millennials (58.6%) saying they find job hunting difficult, the latest round of YouGov-*Mint*-CPR Millennial Survey showed.

However, beyond the collective despair over lack of access to quality education and jobs, what made the student protest bigger than anyone could have anticipated was the zeal of the Gen Zs, born roughly between 1997 and 2012, the oldest among them early into their careers.

A protester in a Darth Vader costume. RUPANJAL CHAUHAN

UNSERIOUSLY SERIOUS

The foundation of the Gen Z protest was a meme—the Cockroach Janata Party, or CJP—and through its serious demands and an arguably historical achievement, it has stayed true to its humour. The protesters had turned the movement into a festive-like celebration of solidarity, singing and dancing to patriotic songs, holding placard-sized printouts of popular memes, and joking with police officials.

"Didi hume bohot peeta, par hum kahin nahi gaye (they beat us up, but we didn't go anywhere)," said two 17-year-old girls at the protest, laughing, but requesting not to be identified. An elderly lady went viral online as she held a placard that read: "Keep your police baton behind. Only I can beat my children". After Pradhan's resignation, a woman held the famous 'Hum Jeet Gaye' meme from Lagaan, another thanked the Gen Zs—popularly tagged the most 'unserious' generation—for "their audacity".

The protest also became a symbol of women displaying extraordinary courage. A viral picture from Mumbai, showing a 27-year-old woman standing in front of a police van alone, encouraged 32-year-old Soumya Prerna, working with a civil services coaching startup, to join the protest in Delhi on Saturday, her weekly day off.

LONG ROAD AHEAD

By Saturday evening, after Pradhan's resignation, several protesters started returning home, while some stayed back to celebrate what is now being seen as one of the most defining moments under the current government.

"The resignation is not the end, it's a beginning. We'll come back again if something happens in the future," said 17-year-old Sona Malik from Delhi, who wishes to become a lawyer.

Experts see the protest as a moment of reckoning but say drastic measures will be needed to fix the system and restore the public's trust in the administration. "This should be an opportunity to sit back and remodel the education system so that the people who come out of this system can straightaway join the workforce," said P.C. Mohanan, former acting chairman of the National Statistical Commission. The core concern is expanding employment opportunities that appear very bleak now, as well as bringing scientific temperament into the system, he added.

From the need for a substantially higher investment in education to a push for labour-intensive sectors and raising female labour force participation rate, the list is long. "The demographic dividend is not automatic and its window is finite," said Chakraborty, the NIPFP professor. "Capital-intensive 'growth champions' alone will not absorb the cohort entering the workforce each year."

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OUR VIEW


AP

Forced labour: US tariff games demand scrutiny

As US trade barriers pivot from one law to another for support, the odds of judicial relief must not weaken. But nor can India flatly deny the warts and woes of its labour market

On 24 July, India was slapped with a new US tariff of 10% to replace one that expired. It was among 60 countries this levy was applied to, though it faces a slightly lower rate than Asian rivals like China and Vietnam, thanks to a recent order barring imports made with forced labour. The 10% duty that was replaced drew on Section 122 of the 1974 US Trade Act, with a 'problem' of payments cited to invoke it. This was both temporary and flaky (the US prints the dollar), but served as a quick resort after America's apex court turfed out last year's big-bang tariffs this February. The US had erected those 'Liberation Day' import barriers in 2025 on the pretext of a trade deficit cast as an 'emergency'; hollow as this claim was, given the country's capital inflows, it stumbled on White House overreach, not on flawed economics. If due process is all that counts, then what was dusted off to justify Friday's barrier, Section 301 of the Trade Act, would seem less flimsy as a tariff-policy wrapper. After all, its use requires a probe of countries alleged to be cheating the US through exports on the back of unfair practices such as forced labour, which is relevant to trade for its wage-cost advantage; US sleuths did go through the paces, even if only to conclude trade partners like India had not freed their supply chains of that scourge.

So long as the White House portrays tariffs as a remedy for what it calls injustice done to America by exporters selling Americans stuff made better or cheaper elsewhere, we can expect the US to invoke one law or another in tariff support. So far, this folly hasn't hit the US economy too hard. Yet, over time, a country that fences itself apart from global competition is likely to see its cost base rise and competitive edge rust, as India's pre-1991 closed economy could attest. Tech leadership may help resist that fate, but rejection of free trade on dubious grounds might still cost the US dearly. Alas, a second Section 301 probe is underway to spot "structural excess capacity" among trade partners, India included. All it may take is opaquely spied overcapacity—or an eyebrow raised over factories built at the spur of a state subsidy—for yet another tariff to kick in. Separately, India's generic drug exports face a three-digit US tariff two years hence under Section 232 of its 1962 Trade Expansion Act now that Washington has recast a health bonus as a security threat. If judicial reviews only look at a process tick-box, these new tariffs could stick. That would not just be unfair to the world at large, it would trivialize a serious issue like forced labour.

America's trade law on it echoes the International Labour Organization's (ILO) definition: "All work or service which is exacted from any person under the menace of any penalty and for which the said person has not offered himself voluntarily." But the US not only has a larger list of specific bans than the ILO, its special bars on captive labour—aimed at China, mostly—deem specified imports tainted unless proven otherwise. While India has long outlawed forced labour and human bondage, gaps in enforcement afflict only informal work—and rarely, if ever, any export value chains. This is reason enough to put the US probe under scrutiny. Meanwhile, last week's street stir back home may have given 'forced labour' its own spin. Youth aiming for well-paid careers complain of being pushed into modest jobs. As AI looms larger by the day, slow upward mobility might be a far bigger worry than US trade rigidity.

MY VIEW | THE INTERSECTION

Biotech: redesign this industry's governance for it to make waves

New Delhi should act urgently as the industry gets squeezed between US tariffs and Chinese leaps

NITIN PAI
is co-founder and director of The Takshashila Institution, an independent centre for research and education in public policy

Biotechnology has become a currency of geopolitical power. Its convergence with artificial intelligence (AI) is transforming the global bio-economy. If India reforms its governance structures, it will open a window of opportunity to becoming a major technological power. If not, our politics, economy and society will have to suffer coercion by countries that have leverage over us. Reforming the biotech sector is no longer only about healthcare, agriculture and economic growth. It has been turned by China and the US into an area of geopolitical contestation. This creates a new salience and urgency.

Last week, the US announced that even generic pharmaceuticals will attract 100% tariff in 2028 and 200% a year after. Patented drugs are already tariffed at 100%. Washington is enacting legislation that could prevent drugs containing Chinese-made ingredients from being imported into the US. Beijing, for its part, has used industrial policy levers to help its firms dominate the global active pharmaceutical ingredients (API) market through pricing power. India's drug industry is caught between the two. Most of our top drug firms and many in the middle segments are adaptive and can invest in becoming globally competitive in this new regime. But many others will face existential pressures, and those that cannot change will be driven out of business. This will have consequences for the domestic economy and global healthcare.

The is just one type of tectonic shift in the larger bio-economy. Rapid advancement in AIxBiotechnology is another. The entire value chain is being shaken up. In pharmaceuticals, everything from drug development, testing, manufacturing and delivery is accelerating at a pace that even the industry—forget governments—can't keep pace with. Technology has moved beyond precision to personalized medicine. Along with genomic databases, biotechnological platforms will form the biological public infrastructure (BPI) that will enable India to address its healthcare challenges and service the world.

India's strategy should be to dominate every part of the value chain in the bio-economy, from the low-end to the high-end because the global opportunity is diverse. This dominance is also the way India can build geopolitical power. If China is a global leader in AI, electric vehicles and renewables today, it is because of decisions Beijing took 15 years ago. Just like in football where you run where the ball is headed, India's national strategy should aim to become a biotech power in a decade.

A Niti Aayog roadmap published this month aims to take the bio-economy from \$195 billion in 2025 to \$691 billion by 2035 and \$2.6 trillion by 2047 and make India among the world's top three biotech powers. This can only be achieved with governance reform.

India still governs its bio-economy using colonial and central planning mindsets. Control and regulation remain the priorities of Indian administrative structures, regardless of the oft-expressed political direction for greater innovation and self-sufficiency. Things will remain the stuck in the old rut unless there is a structural change in the way India governs its bio-economy. Nearly a decade ago, I had argued that the space industry will take off just as the telecom industry did if only we reformed governance structures. It is no different with the bio-economy.

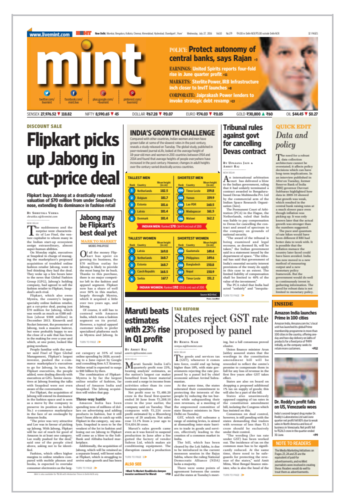
What does reform entail? The administrative and regulatory machinery—spread across different ministries and departments—should be consolidated with the objectives of promoting innovation and growth, as well as safety and effectiveness. Industry promotion must include policies to attract global capital into startups and scale-ups. In a mercantilist world, we should also use fiscal levers to defend India's industry from tariffs, sanctions and subsidies.

Championing the industry goes hand-in-hand, but should be functionally separate from safety and quality control. New Delhi must recognize that bio-economy products, especially pharmaceuticals, will depend more on regulatory credibility and quality assurance in a world of US tariffs and Chinese subsidized low prices. So, upgrading safety and quality standards and assisting the industry to rise up to them are the other side of the industry-promotion coin.

India can justifiably be called the pharmacy of the world. It cannot remain one if Indian companies can only do only 40 first-in-human Phase 1 clinical trials in India while Chinese companies do a thousand. In the typical two years that it takes to get regulatory approval for Phase 1 trials in India, Chinese firms would have completed Phase 2 and would be nearly ready to market. There are good reasons to take a conservative and responsible approach to clinical trials. Given the vast difference in numbers and time-scales achieved, timelines in India are more driven by distrust, rent-seeking and control-mindedness. What is true for clinical trials is also true for other aspects of the bio-economy where regulation is carried out just for regulation's sake.

The hurdles and potholes on India's road to becoming a global biotech power are linked to an outdated governance structure and mindset. American tariffs and Chinese breakthroughs call upon New Delhi to shake itself out of it.

10 YEARS AGO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INDIA'S GROWTH CHALLENGE

TALLEST MEN

Rank	Country	Mean height (in cm)
1	Netherlands	182.5
2	Belgium	181.7
3	Estonia	181.6
4	Latvia	181.4
5	Denmark	181.4

SHORTEST MEN

Rank	Country	Mean height (in cm)
200	Timor Leste	159.8
199	Yemen	159.9
198	Lao PDR	160.5
197	Madagascar	161.5
196	Malawi	162.2

INDIAN MEN: Ranked 178 (164.9 cm) out of 200

TALLEST WOMEN

Rank	Country	Mean height (in cm)
1	Latvia	169.8
2	Netherlands	168.7
3	Estonia	168.7
4	Czech Republic	168.5
5	Serbia	167.7

SHORTEST WOMEN

Rank	Country	Mean height (in cm)
200	Guatemala	149.4
199	Philippines	149.6
198	Bangladesh	150.8
197	Nepal	150.9
196	Timor Leste	151.2

INDIAN WOMEN: Ranked 192 (152.6 cm) out of 200

Tribunal rules against govt for cancelling Devas contract

QUICK EDIT
Data and policy

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INSIDE
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Dr. Reddy's profit falls on US, Venezuela woes
NOTE TO READERS

JUST A THOUGHT

War—whether waged with weapons or tariffs—brings only loss. Civilization thrives on cooperation, not conflict.

BHUWAN THAPALIYA

MY VIEW | MODERN TIMES

The less obvious reason why the BJP may be in trouble

MANU JOSEPH

is a journalist, novelist, and the creator of the Netflix series, 'Decoupled'

For decades there has been a covenant between India and its young—pass these entrance exams, and you are set. You can then escape India, physically and even within India. It was the privatization of hope. In return, the young wasted their youth in the gloom of preparing for life, to make it to some humid town where there would be an 'institution of excellence.'

So, when news exploded that Indian corruption also extended to a major entrance exam, whose question papers were leaked and sold, and that the government messed up exams in other ways, a vast swathe of young people and their parents were disgusted enough to hit the streets, swayed by the cunning provocations of the Cockroach Janta Party. The agitation has since become broader and captured the prevailing anxiety over the economy and lack of employment. But this is not why the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), despite its salvage efforts, may be in its most serious spot of trouble after Narendra Modi took charge as Prime Minister in 2014.

At first glance, it may appear so. But I feel something more fascinating is going on, something new, and it cannot be fixed by this government.

The real problem is this. Higher education has hinged on a lie. That it can result in a good job. For decades there seemed to be a correlation between higher education and lucrative jobs. But, in reality, it was always inequality that helped people secure such jobs. As more and more people could afford education, and were well-fed enough to crack entrance exams, employers just couldn't absorb so many. Higher education was an artificial filter designed to reject millions of people.

Education is many wonderful things. I am sure there are people who study engineering to enjoy the poetic beauty of mechanics, medicine to marvel at the human form and statistics to unearth truth, but mostly people get educated to get a job. It is useless though, if education is not an elite club. Without inequality, education is merely about learning.

The sacred utility of higher education is such an entrenched belief that the government has increased the number of elite engineering and management courses, perhaps thinking, oddly, that if there are many engineers, there would be more jobs.

Yet, millions of graduates are both unemployed and unemployable. Because 'expertise' was always a byproduct of an unequal society. Even technical jobs require elements of social class, like appearance and confident articulation. So hundreds of thousands of students, the poor especially, whose parents borrowed money to send them to college, have no special prospects.

Thus the contract between India and its young cannot be sustained. There is nothing even a competent government, let alone this one, can do about it. That is why the trouble the BJP might now be in is unprecedented. Even if India shifts from organized intellectuality to vocational training, there are just too many of us. The effect of inequality is visible even in modest jobs. Looks like the world was built on a model that is not ready for our sweetest wish—an equal society.

The party is at risk for the first time of being cast in a mould from which there seems no escape

The old arrangement was that a lucky few would get prestigious degrees in prestigious-sounding courses, giving them the appearance of qualification. The elite would then move on to better things, and the next rung would take their place. But the force of social progress, along with powerful publicity of the lie that higher education will save everyone, has ensured that too many are now 'qualified.'

We are watching the full chaos of social progress, compounded by AI. India is so vast that even the top 10% who have 'made it' are a huge number, and their disenchantment is a powerful political force.

The Centre responded to youth protests the way it usually does—through brutal force and intimidation. But that backfired. Anyone who had a child felt their heart twist every time they saw cops hit the young. As the protest swelled and acquired the appearance of a party, it got harder to tell what the protestors wanted, but a vocal section wanted the downfall of this administration.

For the first time, the BJP has been cast as a party that is out of touch with the young, as a fellowship of the old harming the young. And for the first time in over a decade, it may even be looking beatable in national polls.

The last time the BJP faced such negative branding was in the 1990s, when it was deemed 'communal,' which was a bad word in India then and most people were under pressure to claim they were 'secular,' which was mostly nonsense but we were still innocent. Now, the party might be acquiring a reputation for being an enemy of the young.

Indians have a low bar for many things. Our protests for clean air and liveable cities did not rattle politicians. But Indians are hysterically serious about their children. The present is just a temporary holding place for them to shine in a place called the 'future.' Any threat to the future is grave. They can bring up their children in filthy air, let them dangle from unsafe trains and travel on dangerous roads, but they will not tolerate that terrifying thing called an uncertain future. Of such a future, the BJP may now be a mascot.

Just how bad this is for the BJP can be measured in the new courage of Indian celebrities, who have been fearful of saying anything critical against the government. Now they have found their voice.

All this has come at a time when Donald Trump has made it very risky for Indians to escape to America. As a result, the present young are the first generation in modern India that has no choice but to make home a better place. There are no escape hatches.

MY VIEW | GENERAL DISEQUILIBRIUM

Stronger democracy is vital for India's global leadership dreams

Stronger institutions and greater respect for human rights would make it easier for New Delhi to rally other nations together

RAJRISHI SINGHAL
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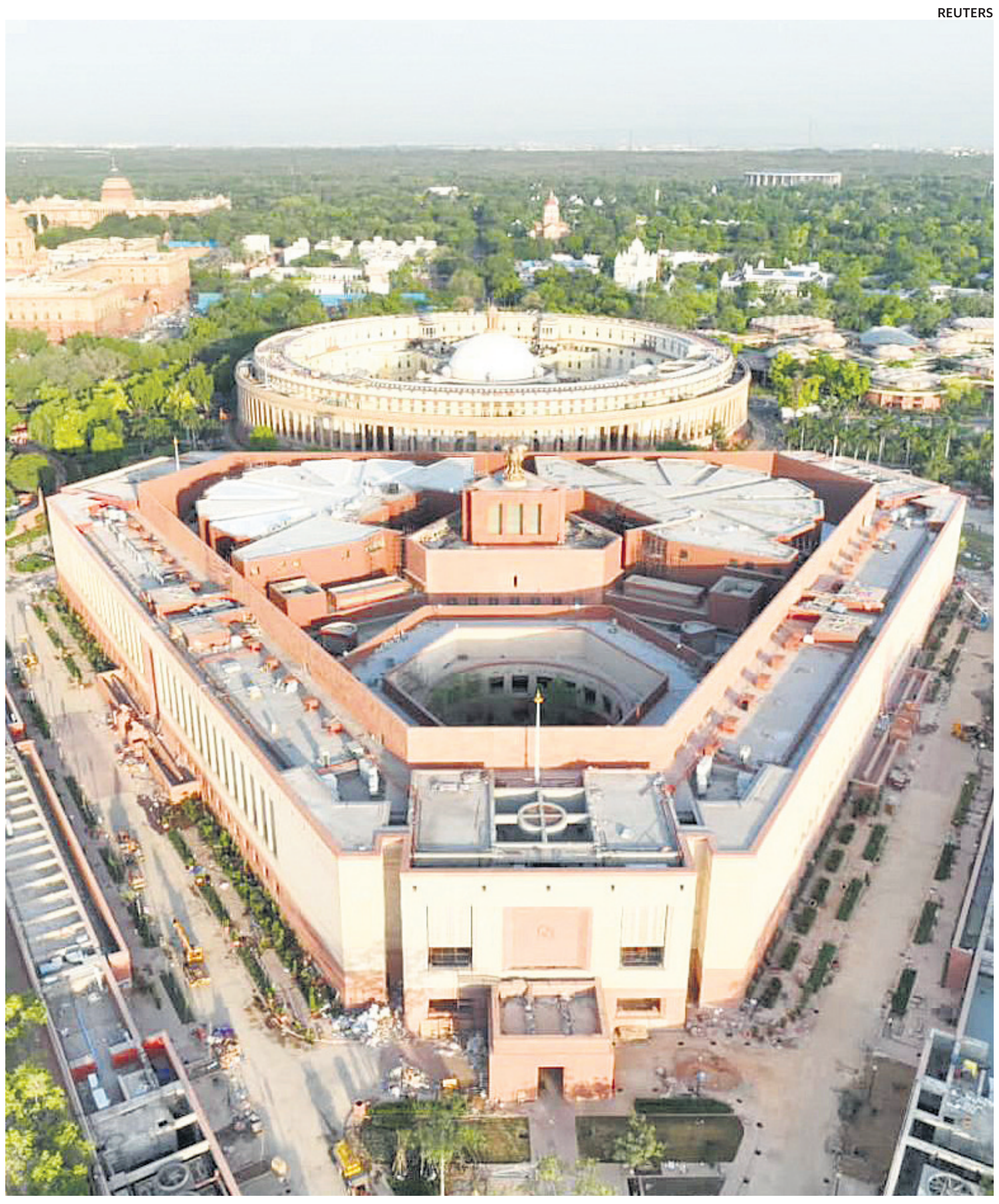
REUTERS



Fans of Chinese author Liu Cixin's science fiction trilogy, loosely called *The Three-Body Problem*, range from former US president Barack Obama to Meta founder Mark Zuckerberg and author George R.R. Martin (of *A Song of Ice and Fire* fame, the book on which *Game of Thrones* is based). *The Three Body Problem* starts its journey in the 1960s China of cultural revolution excesses, segues to the present and then gradually travels thousands of light-years into the future. The book's title refers to a distant planet located in a solar system with three suns which, drawing references from Newtonian physics, renders it unstable and unpredictable. The resulting climatic extremes force the planet's civilizations to go through alternating cycles of prosperity and obliteration. And then the planet's citizens discover Earth, thanks to a politically discredited Chinese astrophysicist posted to a secret radio-frequency transmitting and receiving facility.

The trilogy means many things to many people. For example, the scientifically minded might appreciate how the book examines whether the laws of physics are universal. At its heart, though, the work remains an allegory for climate disasters and the ensuing competition for resources. It also interrogates what kind of domestic politics makes a nation-state vulnerable to external depredations. Let's unpack this.

The history of planet Earth, for example, can be viewed as a series of wars. Many of these were fought for burnishing the ruler's ego, many others were pursued for a naked power grab or to finesse a succession battle; but many wars were also waged for control over natural resources, whether it was aquatic, agricultural or mineral. Historians claim that the first war for resources probably occurred around 2500 BCE in Sumeria (modern-day Iraq) for control over irrigated farmlands. Passage of time does not dampen this aggression: fast forward to 1991, and we had Iraq attacking Kuwait over oil, or to 2003, when the US attacked Iraq (under the pretext of eliminating weapons of mass destruction) to control oilfields. This is just Iraq over the millennia; extrapolate the story across the world and imagine the violence unleashed for resources. Colonial extraction of natural resources, using brutal and coercive methods, created prosperity for many European powers. Violent appropriation of land belonging to native Americans, and the systematic extinction of their tribes, allowed settler colonies in the US to generate agricultural surpluses.

Russia's war with Ukraine, for example, has undertones of both an ego-trip and aggressive acquisition of natural resources. Look at Russia's occupied zones in Ukraine: Donetsk, which used to produce half of Ukraine's coal and finished steel, now services the Russian military; Kherson—a major agricultural hub for cereals, sunflowers and vegetables—now adds to Russian exports; Zaporizhzhia once supplied 25% of Ukraine's electricity, but is now Moscow's strategic asset. And though US President Donald Trump's repeated threats to annex Greenland were couched in geopolitical terms, it is a reasonable bet that his covetous gaze was actually lit up by the region's vast and untapped reserves of rare-earth minerals. China has leveraged its Belt and Road Initiative to bind many resource-rich but underdeveloped nations in crippling debts.

This naked smash-and-grab tendency among the rich and powerful has sent shivers down many a resource-rich nation. Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney's speech at Davos this February, urging middle powers to band together over shared values, has struck a common chord: "Middle powers must act together because if you are not at the table, you are on the menu." While Carney's call to arms was initially viewed with some scepticism, given the wide ideological divergences among middle powers, the idea is resonating once again in the backdrop of renewed superpower belligerence.

N.K. Singh, a former Indian bureaucrat and member of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party, has written (*tinyurl.com/3e5e8kd9*) that India is well-positioned to provide leadership to fragmented blocs and construct an environment of "conscious cooperation" among middle powers.

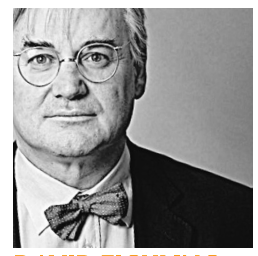
This is where Liu's investigation of a nation's domestic politics and its interplay with global peers, especially in the context of erecting a common front against common challenges, assumes importance. While the trilogy's initial critique of state-sponsored intolerance that later morphs into an endorsement for authoritarian efficiency is politically confusing, its demand for interrogating internal contradictions remains undeniable. Singh's call for India's leadership of middle powers fails to take into account many shortcomings in the context of an apparent democratic deficit. An increasing number of population cohorts—students, farmers and sportspersons—have had to take to the streets to make the administration hear and heed their demands. The administration, unfortunately, has often responded with silence and suboptimal responses.

This is not to deny India's potential to be part of a middle-power multilateral resurgence. But a key factor behind such a platform coalescing under New Delhi's leadership will be India's democracy quotient. In the middle of the 20th century, when many former colonies were gaining independence, India stood out for choosing democracy and democratic institutions rather than authoritarian rule. It is time to regain some of that global admiration.

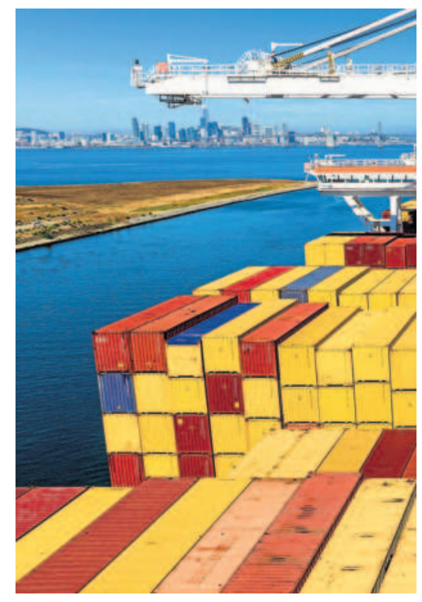
MINT CURATOR

Ports are making electrifying progress on carbon reduction

Shipping will take longer but its land operations are going electric



DAVID FICKLING
is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering climate change and energy.



Seaborne cargo is a hard-to-abate sector but ports are in clean-up mode. AP

If there is one place you would have expected the march of electrified clean energy to be dragging its feet, it is ports. At harbours such as Singapore and Port Said, the growth of trade in goods through the 20th century was inextricably bound up with transporting and storing the fossil fuels that ocean-going vessels used for their power. Cargo shipping, responsible for about 3% of global emissions, tends to rank high on lists of so-called 'hard-to-abate' industries like aviation, steel, chemicals and cement, which are so bound up with the carbon economy that they will resist the switch to clean alternatives until the bitter end.

Right now, the prospects of an energy transition here might seem remote. Ocean-going trade is in the midst of its biggest crisis in a generation, with the Strait of Hormuz closed off by the US and Israel fighting with Iran, and the conflict now spreading to a potential renewed blockade of the Red Sea by Yemen's Houthi militia.

And yet, when the dust settles, it is remarkable how quickly parts of the sector have been quietly going electric. Almost all large gantry cranes—the vast metal structures that move shipping containers from deck to shore and around the port—are now grid-powered rather than dependent on engines. Smaller, more mobile rubber-tired gantries, which traditionally used diesel and accounted for an outsized share of emissions and particulate pollution from ports, are headed in the same direction: In 2024, about 28% of sales were battery-operated, with a further 17% hybrid. At Konecranes, one of the biggest suppliers of such equipment, some 62% of sales last year were battery or hybrid.

These shifts take advantage of several factors common to all docks. The power requirements of the machinery to move cargo around the port and to nearby rail terminals—gantries, forklifts, yard tractors, trucks—can be immense. The equipment often is in constant motion, meaning plugging it into a cable is not an option. But the distances covered tend to be small and route patterns fairly predictable, making it easy to mesh operations with the daily charging demands of battery power.

That means harbours are unusually amenable to a technological switch as battery technology improves. Ports as businesses are also well placed to upgrade their equipment. Unlike road freight and container shipping, the sector tends to be profitable and stable. That means there is plenty of cash flow to invest in electrification, especially if it will lead to better margins in the long term. Ports are also often quasi-monopolies that operate via concessions from the cities that host them. As a result, they are keen to reduce the nuisance their pollution causes to residents and voters.

The effects can be seen around the world. At Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority, which operates India's second-biggest container terminal near Mumbai, 90% of the truck fleet will have been electrified by the end of this year. A fifth of cargo-handling equipment at the Port of Long Beach, near Los Angeles, is electric. Tuas, the zone under construction in Singapore that is intended to be the world's largest container terminal when completed in 2040, is being designed almost entirely around grid and battery power.

Ships are plugging into the grid, too. Vessels once used to consume their own fuel when docked using auxiliary engines, but that practice can be carbon-heavy. Nowadays, most Chinese and European container and cruise ports provide shore electricity through immense cables.

Even water-going craft are starting to switch. Tugboats are unusual in shipping because their most important attribute is not sustained power but the ability to get a larger vessel moving and change its direction—what engineers call torque. High and instant torque is the reason electric cars can accelerate faster than conventional vehicles; it is a fundamental advantage of electric-powered motors over combustion engines. An electric tug that has been operating in Auckland since 2022 costs only half as much to operate as a diesel version. Singapore started using its first electric tug models earlier this year.

Getting fossil fuels out of ships' engines will be the hardest part, although even there small battery-powered container ships are entering service. Electrifying shore-based operations, though, is low-hanging fruit. Just 25 harbours handle about half of all container trade and in total there are only about 1,000 such ports on the planet.

The strides they are making offer the world a test-bed for how battery-powered machinery could transform the global trucking and logistics industry that accounts for around 8% of the world's emissions. Under our noses, a worldwide industrial ecosystem is rapidly switching to clean power.

THEIR VIEW

Why we must not fall victim to AI's illusion of wisdom

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When Ford Motor Co. recently announced that it was bringing back hundreds of experienced engineers to strengthen product quality, it delivered one of the most important lessons of the artificial intelligence (AI) era. After years of expanding the use of AI and automated engineering systems, Ford acknowledged that inspection systems failed to deliver the results. Kumar Galhotra, its chief operating officer, admitted: "We had been relying more and more on automated quality systems and not getting the desired results. We brought back technical specialists, and they hunt for failure points before a part ever reaches the plant floor."

Ford's experience should not be dismissed as an isolated engineering setback. It is an example of the illusion of wisdom that AI creates. A process can be automated, but not wisdom. Interestingly, history offers a useful parallel. During the 1990s, organizations rushed to embrace enterprise software and workflow automation, believing that digitizing existing processes would automatically improve 'productivity.' Ironically, many simply automate inefficiency. Management thinker Michael Hammer captured this lesson in his famous dictum: "Don't automate, obliterate." Technology should redesign work rather than merely accelerate flawed processes. AI risks repeating that mistake on a far greater scale.

Much of the public debate has focused on whether it will eliminate jobs. However, the deeper and less appreciated risk is epistemic. AI is changing not only how we work, but how we decide what to believe. Two pieces of work are relevant in the context of Ford. Herbert Simon observed over half a century ago that a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention. As information becomes abundant and cheap, human attention and judgement become scarce. Three decades later, James Surowiecki (2004) argued, albeit in a different context, that the "wisdom of crowds" emerges only under specific conditions: individuals must think independently, possess diverse information and perspectives, and combine their judgements through effective mechanisms. Collective wisdom, therefore, depends not merely on having many opinions but on those opinions remaining genuinely independent and diverse. AI threatens at least two of these conditions: As millions of people rely on the same AI model, their judgements get correlated and lose independence. Also, large language models often produce similar consensus-like answers, reducing the diversity of viewpoints. Therefore, instead of amplifying the 'wisdom of crowds,' AI risks creating what one can call the 'illusion of wisdom,' as many people arrive at the same answer not because it is correct, but because it was generated by similar underlying models.

The wisdom of crowds could fail humanity if independent judgement becomes a casualty of AI

There are other information-based theories that can help us understand the dynamics of such suboptimal choices in the AI era. For example, economists Sushil Bikhchandani, David Hirshleifer and Ivo Welch have shown how informational cascades arise when individuals rationally ignore their private information after observing others' actions. Similarly, Stephen Morris and Hyun Song Shin identified a different but equally powerful mechanism. When everyone observes the same public signal, rational decision-makers place excessive weight on it because they know everyone else is observing it too. The common signal becomes a focal point for coordination. If it is wrong, mistakes become widespread even though people may be responding rationally to the same source of information.

Generative AI combines elements of both mechanisms while creating a new challenge. *First*, AI eliminates information scarcity while making independent human judgement relatively scarce. As machine-generated answers become instantaneous, comprehensive and inexpensive, fewer people invest the effort required to verify them independently. *Second*, repeated exposure to accurate and confident AI-generated responses encourages users to outsource not merely information retrieval but judgement itself. Confidence could gradually become a substitute for competence. *Third*, AI acts as a common informational anchor. Decisions grow increasing correlated because they originate from the same statistical engine. In classical herding, people imitate one another. This differs. Nor is this simply an informational cascade. AI is yielding a world in which independent reasoning is crowded out by the same machine-generated starting point.

The consequences would be profound. The greatest danger is the gradual erosion of society's capacity for independent judgement, which may be worse than an overload of misinformation. Ironically, genuine expertise will be more valuable in a world where the rarest skill will be the ability to recognize when information is incomplete, misleading or simply wrong. Only genuine expertise will be able to break an ugly loop of artificial wisdom.

Three decades ago, Michael Hammer warned managers not to automate bad processes. The AI era demands an even more fundamental warning: do not automate wisdom. Machines can process information at superhuman speed, but wisdom is forged through experience, judgement, accountability and ethical responsibility. If society mistakes statistical predictions for wisdom, the greatest casualty of this technology's rise will not be employment but humanity's capacity to think independently.


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